



UNIVERSITÀ DEGLI STUDI DI MILANO

FACOLTÀ DI SCIENZE POLITICHE,
ECONOMICHE E SOCIALI

Master's Degree in Data Science for Economics

**From Data to Strategy:
Optimizing Tourism Offerings in
Ascoli Piceno**

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Academic Year 2024/2025

Acknowledgments

A mia nonna Chiche, che è ancora presente come sempre. Per il suo amore incondizionato, per avermi sempre aspettato con un sorriso e per avermi sostenuto in ogni passo, anche a distanza. Oggi mi guida dal cielo e la sua forza mi accompagna ogni giorno.

A Delfina, mia moglie, per essere la persona che mi sopporta sempre e con cui ho intrapreso questa meravigliosa avventura in un nuovo continente. Se non fosse stato per lei, forse non avrei mai avuto il coraggio di fare questo passo.

Alla mia famiglia, principalmente ai miei genitori, perché so che questa decisione ci ha allontanati fisicamente e che per loro non è stato facile, ma nonostante tutto mi hanno sempre sostenuto a distanza.

A Massimo, per aver accettato di essere il mio tutor e per avermi accompagnato in quest'ultimo passo del master. Inoltre, per avermi fatto scoprire questa bellissima città che è Ascoli Piceno.

A Giorgia, per il suo supporto prezioso, i suoi contributi e la sua guida durante lo sviluppo di questa tesi.

Ai miei amici dell'Argentina, e soprattutto a tutti gli amici che ho conosciuto durante questa bellissima esperienza qui in Italia, che mi hanno fatto crescere personalmente, mi hanno avvicinato a nuove culture e modi di vivere che non avrei mai immaginato di conoscere, e che nei momenti più difficili sono stati al mio fianco, spingendomi a non mollare mai.

A me stesso, perché nonostante la paura di volare, ho avuto il coraggio di salire sull'aereo e intraprendere questa meravigliosa avventura. E, soprattutto, per la perseveranza nel continuare ad andare avanti nonostante gli ostacoli lungo il cammino.

E a questo bellissimo paese da cui proveniva il mio bisnonno e che mi ha accolto per vivere una delle esperienze più belle della mia vita. Sono arrivato come argentino e ora sono "argentano", orgoglioso di essere tornato alle mie radici.

To my grandmother Chiche, who remains as present as ever. For her unconditional love, for always waiting for me with a smile, and for supporting me every

step of the way, even from afar. Today she guides me from heaven, and her strength walks with me every day.

To Delfina, my wife, for being the person who always supports me and with whom I embarked on this beautiful adventure in a new continent. If it hadn't been for her, I might never have dared to take this step.

To my family, especially my parents, because I know that this decision distanced us physically and was difficult for them, yet they have always supported me.

To Massimo, for accepting to be my tutor and guiding me through this final step of the master's program. Also, for introducing me to this wonderful city, Ascoli Piceno.

To Giorgia, for her invaluable support, insights, and guidance throughout the development of this thesis.

To my friends from Argentina, and especially to all the friends I made during this beautiful experience here in Italy, who helped me grow personally, introduced me to new cultures and ways of life I never imagined I'd discover, and who stood by my side during the most difficult moments, encouraging me to never give up.

To myself, because despite my fear of flying, I had the courage to get on the plane and embark on this incredible journey. And, above all, for the perseverance to keep moving forward despite the obstacles along the way.

And finally, to this beautiful country where my bisnonno was from, which welcomed me and allowed me to have one of the greatest experiences of my life. I came as an Argentinian and now I am an "Argentano," proud to have reconnected with my roots.

A mi abuela Chiche, que sigue tan presente como siempre. Por su amor incondicional, por esperarme siempre con una sonrisa, y por apoyarme en cada paso, incluso en la distancia. Hoy me guía desde el cielo, y su fuerza me acompaña cada día.

A Delfina, mi esposa, por ser la persona que siempre me aguanta y con quien emprendí esta hermosa aventura en un nuevo continente. Si no hubiese sido por ella, quizá nunca me habría animado a dar este paso.

A mi familia, principalmente a mis padres, porque sé que esta decisión nos alejó físicamente y les costó, pero aun así siempre me apoyaron a la distancia.

A Massimo, por haber aceptado ser mi tutor y acompañarme en este último escalón del máster. Además, por haberme presentado esta hermosa ciudad que es Ascoli Piceno.

A Giorgia, por su apoyo invaluable, sus aportes y su guía a lo largo del desarrollo de esta tesis.

A mis amigos de Argentina, y principalmente todos los amigos que me hice en esta hermosa experiencia acá en Italia, quienes me hicieron crecer personalmente, me acercaron a nuevas culturas y formas de vivir que jamás imaginé conocer, y que en los momentos más difíciles estuvieron a mi lado, impulsándome a nunca bajar los brazos.

A mí mismo, porque más allá del miedo a volar, tuve el coraje de subirme al avión y emprender esta hermosa aventura. Y, sobre todo, por la perseverancia de seguir adelante a pesar de los obstáculos en el camino.

Y a este hermoso país del que era mi bisnonno y que me recibió para vivir una de las mejores experiencias de mi vida. Vine como argentino y ahora soy un “argentano”, orgulloso de haber vuelto a mis raíces.

Franco Reinaldo Bonifacini

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Abstract

Tourism plays a fundamental role in the economic development of many Italian cities, including Ascoli Piceno, a destination with significant untapped potential. Despite its rich cultural, historical, and gastronomic heritage, the city has yet to establish itself as a highly competitive tourist destination compared to other Italian locations.

This project analyzes tourism data from various Italian cities to identify key trends in visitor segmentation, pricing models, and market positioning. To address this challenge, this study seeks to answer the following research question: "What is the optimal combination of pricing, positioning, and promotional strategies for Ascoli Piceno to increase tourism competitiveness?". By combining secondary data analysis with primary research through surveys, the project provides insights into tourist preferences, spending behavior, and the effectiveness of different promotional strategies. Additionally, financial factors—including cost structures, potential partnerships, and the role of influencer marketing—are examined to understand their impact on tourism promotion.

Using clustering techniques and strategic pricing models, the research proposes optimized tourism packages tailored to different market segments. The findings aim to offer evidence-based recommendations for Ascoli Piceno to improve its tourism appeal, increase visitor numbers, and strengthen its overall economic sustainability. Further research could explore the long-term effects of these strategies and identify additional factors that influence the competitiveness of tourist destinations.

Chapter 1

Introduction

This chapter introduces the context and motivation behind this thesis. It first presents an overview of tourism at the global, national, and local levels, showing its importance and recent trends. The focus then narrows to Italy and finally to Ascoli Piceno, the case study of this work. By looking at data on arrivals, overnight stays, and spending patterns, this section provides a clear picture of the tourism situation. The chapter also briefly describes the previous work that inspired this research and explains how this thesis builds on it with a more detailed and structured approach.

1.1 Tourism Through the Data Lens

1.1.1 Tourism on a Global Scale

Tourism is recognized as one of the most important economic sectors in the world. In 2019, it represented a significant share of the global economy, accounting for 7% of global trade. However, despite its importance, tourism was also among the sectors most severely impacted by the Covid-19 pandemic, which affected not only global economies but also livelihoods, public services, and development opportunities in countries across all continents [1]. Now, four years after the onset of the pandemic, the sector has shown strong signs of recovery. International tourist arrivals have returned to 99% of 2019 levels, signaling that tourism has bounced back from what is considered the worst crisis in its history [2]. As shown in Figure 1.1, in addition to the rebound in arrivals, there has also been a notable rise in international tourism revenues. Total international tourism receipts reached USD 1.7 trillion in 2024, reflecting a 10.5% increase compared to 2023 and a 14.1% increase from 2019 in real terms [3].

Moreover, when the data is broken down by region, it becomes clear that the Middle East continued to be the best-performing region in 2024. As shown in

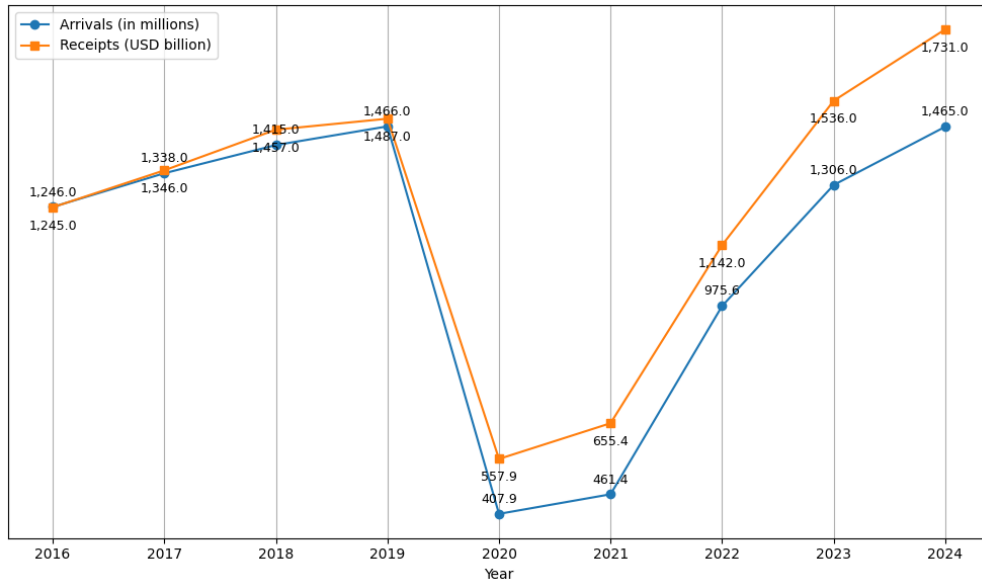


Figure 1.1: *International Tourist Arrivals & Receipts*. Source: UNWTO.

Figure 1.2, this region experienced a strong growth in tourist arrivals, which were 32% above 2019 levels and also showed a 1% increase compared to 2023. In the case of Africa, the continent received 7% more tourists than it did before the pandemic began, indicating a solid recovery. Europe, known as the world's largest destination region, also showed positive results by recording 1% more international tourist arrivals than in 2019. Meanwhile, the Americas managed to recover 97% of its pre-pandemic tourist numbers, which is just a 3% decrease compared to 2019. Finally, the region of Asia and the Pacific reached 87% of its 2019 levels, showing a 13% decline in international arrivals compared to the pre-pandemic period [2].

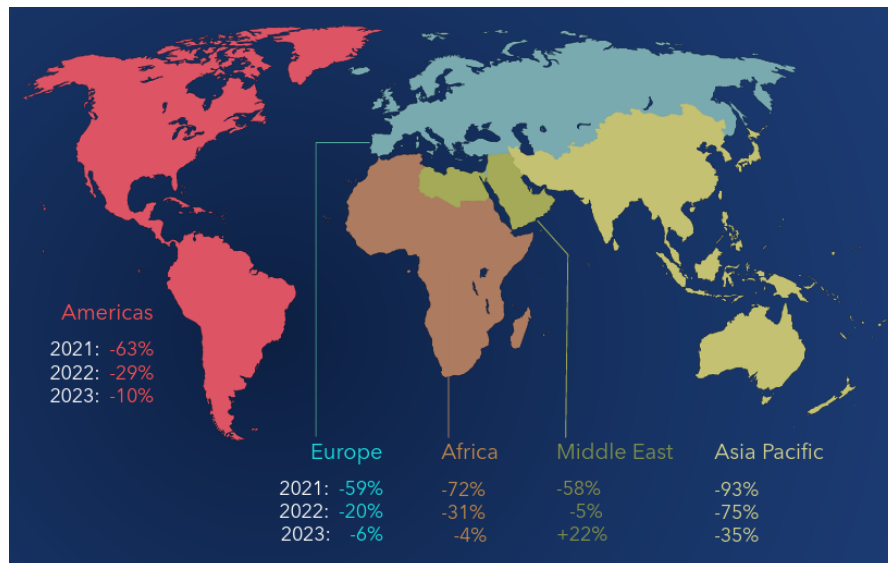


Figure 1.2: *International Tourist Arrivals by Region (% change vs 2019)*. Source: UNWTO.

Nevertheless, when considering absolute values, Europe continues to dominate

global tourism (see Figure 1.3). In 2024, the region recorded approximately 755.7 million international tourist arrivals, accounting for 52% of total global arrivals. In terms of expenditure, Europe generated an estimated USD 725.3 billion in international tourism receipts, representing 42% of the world’s total [3].

These not only confirm Europe’s position as the most visited region globally but also highlight its high capacity for monetizing tourism flows. The average revenue per international arrival in Europe stood at around USD 960, while the global average is around USD 1,182 per tourist in 2024. This gap highlights the advantage of Europe, where shorter trips and lower per-capita spending are more common compared to other top regions such as Amercias (around USD 1,814) and Middle East (around USD 1,458).

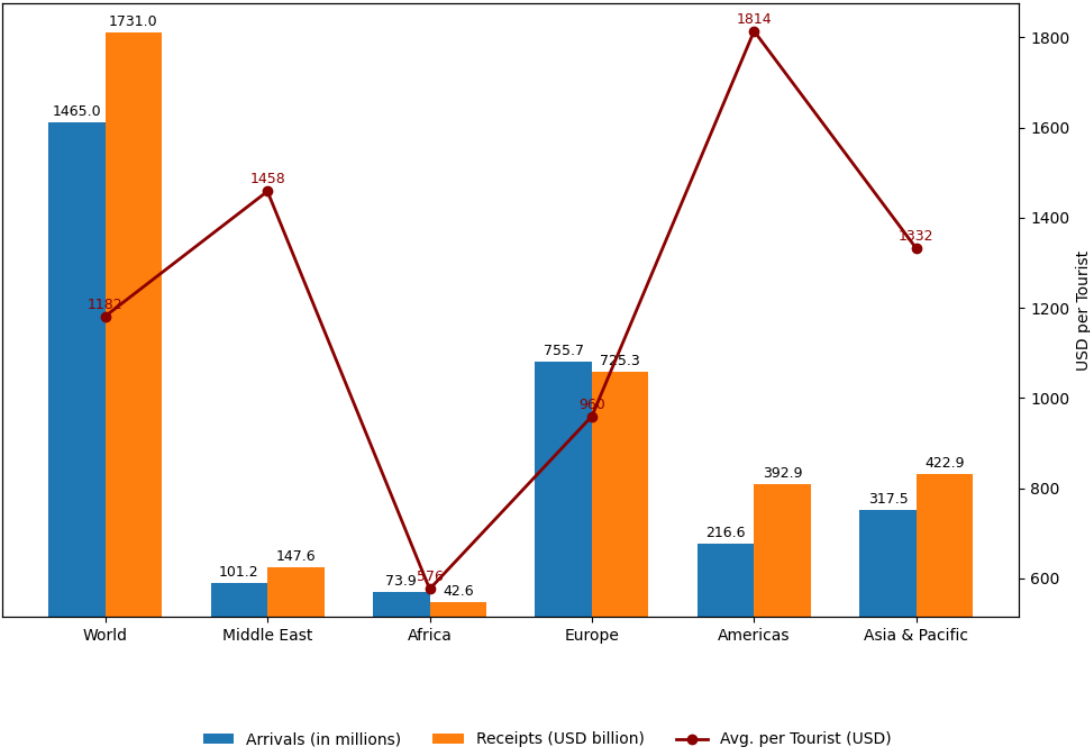


Figure 1.3: *Arrivals, Receipts, and Avg. Spend per Tourist.* Source: UNWTO.

1.1.2 The Italian Context

International Tourism and Overnight Stays

Italy continues to be a an important destination for international tourism, ranked among the top 5 countries in the world, behind Türkiye who had 60.6 million visitors (see Figure 1.4). The country counts with a rich cultural heritage, natural beauty, and culinary excellence. However, recent trends show a mixed picture in terms of volume and economic impact. According to the United Nations

World Tourism Organization (UNWTO), Italy recorded 57.8 million international tourist arrivals in 2024, which reflects a 10.4% decrease compared to 2019. Despite the decline in visitor numbers, the country experienced a strong financial recovery, with international tourism receipts reaching USD 58.7 billion, an 18.5% increase over 2019 [3]. This highlights that the country has not yet fully returned to its pre-pandemic levels in terms of international arrivals, suggesting that there is still significant room for growth and strategic interventions aimed at increasing the level of tourism.

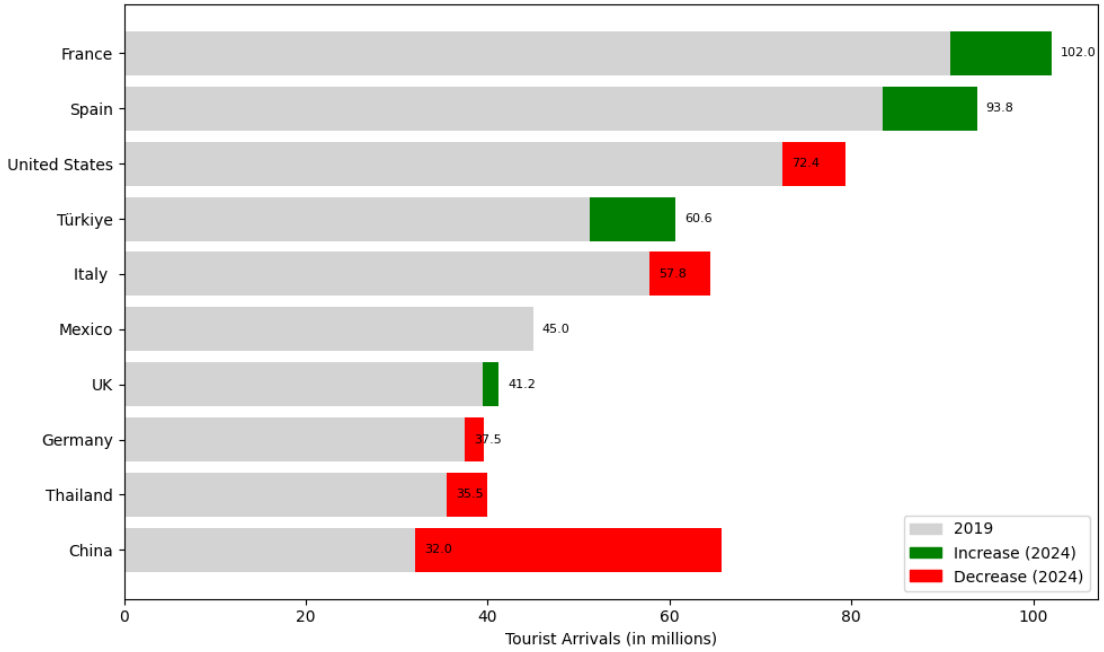


Figure 1.4: *Ranking of International Arrivals by Country. Source: UNWTO.*

Tourism in Italy is also measured by the number of overnight stays in accommodations, where the country positioned itself as the second-largest European destination in terms of total nights spent. According to the Italian National Institute of Statistics (ISTAT), Italy recorded 458.4 million overnight stays in 2024, representing a 2.5% increase compared to 2023. Among these, foreign tourists accounted for around 250 million nights, a 6.8% increase, while domestic stays declined by 2.2%, totaling roughly 208 million nights. Foreign visitors now represent 54.6% of all overnight stays, indicating that international tourism has regained its leading role in the Italian tourism sector. This trend became especially evident in the fourth quarter of 2024, when total overnight stays grew by 11.1%, mainly driven by international travelers (+15.6%), who outnumbered domestic tourists in that quarter for the first time [4].

Spending and Economic Contribution

According to the first edition of the “Tourism and Incoming Watch” report, developed by Nexi in collaboration with the National Tourism Observatory of the Ministry of Tourism, foreign travellers spent over €20.9 billion in Italy in 2024 using payment cards alone, representing a substantial increase of 37.9% compared to 2022. This figure reflects not only the volume of international tourism but also the growing role of digital payments in capturing economic value across the tourism sector [5].

The report also highlighted a notable diversification in the origin of high-spending tourists. Travellers from Brazil and Australia showed the largest increases in card-based spending, with growth rates of +155% and +100%, respectively. Meanwhile, US tourists remained the most significant contributors in absolute terms, with more than €3.8 billion spent, accounting for 18.3% of total foreign tourist expenditure. Tourists from Saudi Arabia (€913) and the United Arab Emirates (€822) had the highest average card spend per transaction, both nearly double the international average of €411 [5].

In terms of spending categories, almost half (49.6%) of all international tourist expenditure in Italy went to restaurants and accommodation services. Fashion and accessories accounted for another 12.2%, with visitors from Arab countries and Southeast Asia allocating an above-average share of their budgets to jewellery and department store shoppings [5].

The geographic distribution of tourist spending also reveals concentration patterns. Just 20 provinces generated 75% of all foreign tourist value, confirming the dominance of Italy’s major cultural and urban destinations: Rome, Milan, Venice, Florence, and Naples. These cities continue to attract visitors and generate sustained economic benefits for the national economy [5].

Among the most popular travel routes, the Rome – Naples and Pompeii – Amalfi Coast circuits generated the highest overall turnover for the third consecutive year, with a 31% increase over the 2022–2024 period. However, the Rome – Florence – Venice itinerary recorded the highest growth rate in the same period, rising by +69.2%. This trend suggests that traditional cultural circuits remain dominant, but their internal dynamics are shifting due to changing tourist preferences and purchasing behaviors [5].

Another key finding is the decline in tourism seasonality. Thanks to diversified travel flows and evolving preferences, international visitor demand is now more evenly distributed throughout the year. This has reinforced Italy’s profile as a year-round destination, which contributes to greater economic resilience and offers new opportunities for regional development beyond the summer peak [5].

1.1.3 Ascoli Piceno

Ascoli Piceno is a historic city located in the Marche region of central Italy, known for its rich cultural heritage, well-preserved medieval architecture, and local traditions. It is a city of ancient origins, once a strategic Roman center along the Via Salaria. Known as the “City of a Hundred Towers”, it has one of the most elegant and well-preserved historical centers in Italy, largely built in travertine stone. The city is renowned for its harmonious urban layout and architectural beauty, especially visible in its iconic squares, Piazza del Popolo and Piazza Arringo, which serve as central hubs of civic and cultural life. Rich in Romanesque, Gothic, and Renaissance heritage, Ascoli offers an authentic and immersive experience in tradition. Its compact, walkable layout and local identity make it an ideal example of high-quality, culture-oriented tourism, away from mainstream destinations [7].

Touristic Situation

Although it experienced a significant increase of +18% in 2024 in tourist arrivals compared to pre-pandemic levels in 2019, Ascoli Piceno still shows clear potential for further growth in tourism. Among Italy’s 5,014 municipalities available in the dataset of ISTAT (Istituto Nazionale di Statistica), Ascoli Piceno ranked 544th in 2024, recording a total of 43,873 arrivals. This figure, while reflecting a notable improvement, remains modest when positioned within the national context. For example, when compared to the top 10 destinations by arrivals in the same year, Ascoli Piceno represents only 0.4% of the total arrivals of Rome, the top-ranked city [6].

Furthermore, as shown in Figure 1.5, it is important to highlight the high concentration of tourism flows among a small group of urban destinations. In fact, the top four cities alone accounted for 19% of all tourist arrivals in Italy in 2024, demonstrating the uneven distribution of tourism across the country. Additionally, the following six cities registered more than one million arrivals each, underlining the dominance of a few key destinations [6]. This disparity reinforces the relevance of studying smaller but culturally rich destinations like Ascoli Piceno, which, despite their lower absolute numbers, contribute to the diversification and sustainability of Italian tourism.

To better understand the evolution of tourism in Italy over the past decade, the Figure 1.6 illustrates the total number of tourist arrivals (in millions) from 2014 to 2024 for the country’s ten most visited municipalities, along with Ascoli Piceno. Rome has consistently maintained its status as Italy’s top tourist destination, with a drop in 2020 due to the COVID-19 pandemic, followed by a strong recovery, exceeding 2019 arrivals in 2024. Milan, Venice, and Florence follow similar trends,

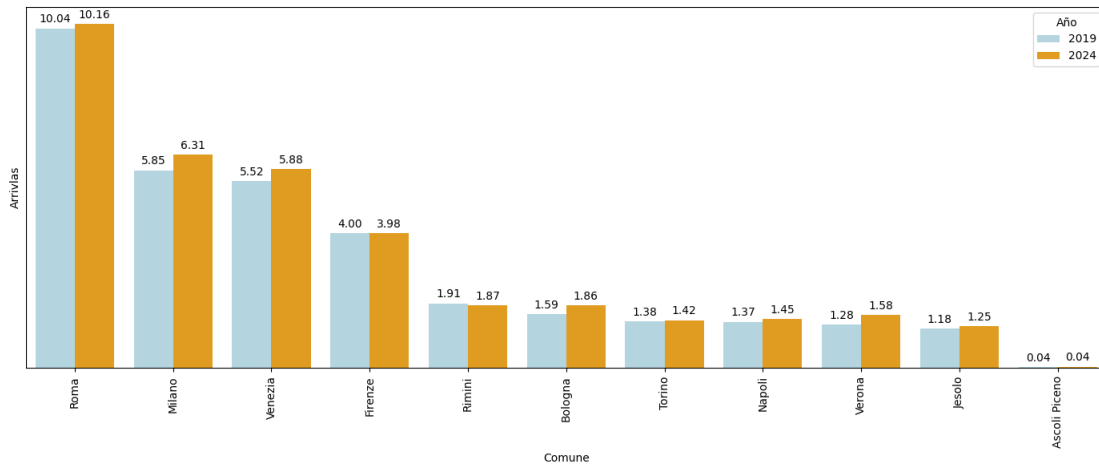


Figure 1.5: *Total Arrivals by Comuna (2019 vs 2024)*. Source: ISTAT.

with notable rebounds after the pandemic-induced decline [6].

In contrast, Ascoli Piceno remains far below these major destinations in terms of tourist volume, never exceeding 0.045 million (45,000) arrivals in any given year. This highlights its marginal role in the Italian tourism market, despite its rich cultural and historical appeal. This gap highlights the need to explore what types of tourists might be interested in discovering lesser-known destinations like Ascoli Piceno, and how they might differ from visitors to Italy’s more popular cities [6].

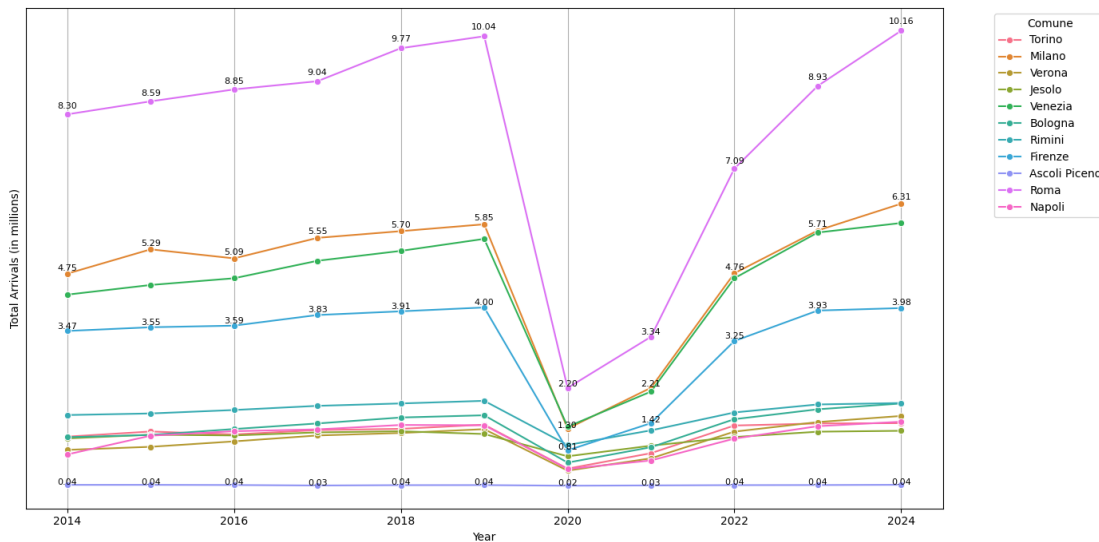


Figure 1.6: *Evolution of Arrivals by Comuna (2014 - 2024)*. Source: ISTAT.

The structure of tourist arrivals by residency category (residents and non-residents) shows notable differences across Italian destinations. As described in sub-section 1.1.2, of this chapter, overnight stays in accommodations by foreign tourists represented 54.6% of all overnight stays, highlighting the relevance of international tourism in the Italian tourism sector. That being said, Figure 1.7 presents

data from 2024 for the ten most visited Italian cities. In the top 4 cities, international (non-resident) arrivals outnumber domestic (resident) arrivals, representing more than 50% of total arrivals [6].

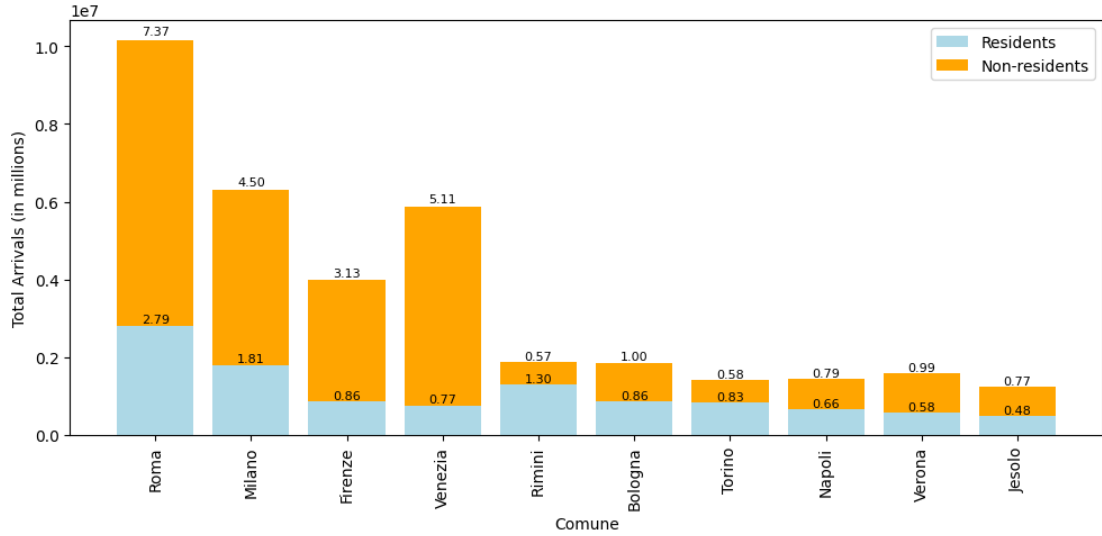


Figure 1.7: *Residents and Non-Residents Arrivals in top cities (2024)*. Source: ISTAT.

On the other hand, Figure 1.8 displays the same information for Ascoli Piceno in 2024. The total number of tourist arrivals is significantly lower than in the top ten destinations. Specifically, Ascoli Piceno registered 37,709 domestic arrivals and 6,164 international arrivals, the last representing only 14.05% of total arrivals. The comparison between Ascoli Piceno and the major Italian tourism destinations, along with national-level data, provides a clear overview of the absolute and relative scale of domestic and international tourism flows within Italy [6].

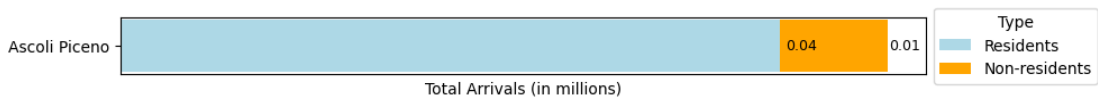


Figure 1.8: *Residents and Non-Residents Arrivals in Ascoli Piceno (2024)*. Source: ISTAT.

Overtourism: Ascoli Piceno’s Opportunity?

Europe has been called the world’s museum, but its record numbers of visitors have also made it ground zero for concerns about overtourism. Among factors driving the record numbers are cheap flights, social media, and the ease of travel planning using artificial intelligence [8]. This matter is something that is not new, and many residents of the affected cities started a time ago with anti-tourism protests, even a new wave of anti-tourism protests is being planned across southern Europe later for this summer (2025) [11]. Furthermore, the potential culprits point the finger at each other. For example, Airbnb says hotels are driving the problem,

while Tui, Europe’s largest hotel operator, has hit back, saying Airbnb is to blame [12].

In Italy, 70% of tourists go to only 1% of Italy’s territory [9]. There are several destinations in the country at risk of overtourism, including popular cities like Rome, Florence, Milan, and Venice, as well as lesser-known cities such as Bolzano, Livorno, and Rimini. According to a study organized by Demoskopika, Bolzano, Livorno, Naples, Rimini, Trento, and Venice are at a high-level risk of overtourism. Following them, at a high-level of overtourism are Aosta, Florence, Forlì-Cesena, Gorizia, Grosseto, Imperia, La Spezia and the Cinque Terre, Milan, Ravenna, Rome, Savona, and Trieste. Taking these into account, there is an immediate need for responsible actions to ensure that tourism contributes to cultural enrichment and economic development without burdening future generations [10]. Taking these into account, and according to Visit Italy CEO and founder Ruben Santopietro, “99% of the destinations in Italy have an incredible capacity to grow”. Nevertheless, this can backfire, as cities with small populations and little tourism infrastructure can be woefully unprepared for hordes of people [9].

Nowadays, the sustainable tourism, term first started to be battled around in the 1990s [9], is gaining terrain in this field. Many destinations are responding with new ideas for a more sustainable travel season. For example, Switzerland’s national train network will be run completely on hydroelectric power this year (2025), as part of its new Swisstainable strategy that aims to distribute tourism more evenly across the country and calendar. The Swisstainable website offers 33% off public transport when booking a sustainability-certified Swisstainable hotel, or 25% off for any stay in a Swisstainable hotel. On the other hand, in Spain they remove nearly 66,000 unregulated Airbnb listings and pulled back on social media influencer campaigns that bring selfie tourists to its small and easily overwhelmed beaches. Also, they developed a digital platform that monitors how many people are on beaches, as well as the air quality, sea temperatures, weather and even jellyfish in the water. These information can be accessed by tourism offices and hoteliers, helping them (and therefore visitors) make smarter decisions about where to go and what to do [11].

1.2 Previous Work

This research originates from a project initially developed for the Marketing Analytics course within the Master’s Degree in Data Science for Economics, for the academic year 2024/2025, at the Università degli studi di Milano. The project had a similar objective to the present work, but was carried out over a shorter time period and primarily aimed at applying the techniques taught during the

course, not too focused on delivering an in-depth analysis to the city. The course had a duration of almost 3 months, and the project had a duration of around 1 month. In view of this, the earlier project presented several limitations, apart from the short timeframe, which are addressed differently and in greater depth in the current thesis.

First, there was a significant limitation in the qualitative interviews conducted during the initial stage of the project (see Appendix A for an example of these interviews). The main objective of these interviews was to collect qualitative data about participants' tourist behaviour, which would then serve as the basis for defining the final attributes to be analysed in the quantitative survey. The main limitation was that the interviews contained a small number of predefined questions that were very specific, leaving little room for respondents to describe their genuine behaviour in a tourist destination. Moreover, this limitation may have resulted in the omission of potential attributes that could have further enriched the study. These "open" questions were formulated so narrowly that interviewees often provided very short answers. Furthermore, the interviews lacked questions related to actual travel experiences, which resulted in a generalised understanding of certain tourist topics rather than experience-based insights.

Second, after the qualitative interviews stage, came the definition of the main attributes. This phase also had its limitations regarding the project's main goal, as it defined very general attributes. Such generalization led to a limited analysis of tourist behaviour, mainly because attributes such as price, food, culture, and accessibility, among others, did not clearly describe specific tourist behaviours, and failed to describe important aspects that Ascoli Piceno could focus on. For instance, the attribute price could refer to food prices, accommodation costs, transportation costs, or even event ticket prices, among others. Moreover, attributes such as price may have been interpreted in opposite ways by different types of respondents (e.g. budget vs premium travellers), leading to answers that looked equally important but for contradictory interpretations. This ambiguity prevented the attributes from effectively discriminating across tourist segments. In addition, most of the interviews were not recorded, so the final transcriptions relied on the interviewer's notes, making it impossible for other team members to verify them and maybe extract more valuable insights. Although the project's final outcome was sufficient for the course's goal, the definition of attributes could have been improved to achieve more precise and insightful results.

Third, the following stage was the online survey, which aimed to obtain quantitative data for the final results and analysis. Although the outcomes were satisfactory and considered sufficient for the course's objective, the total number of responses (80) was relatively low. In terms of sample size, a target of at least 300

responses would have provided a larger and more diverse dataset, thereby strengthening the validity of the results. On the other hand, some questions could have been removed because they were already covered by others, or did not contribute at all. For example, respondents from Italy were asked an additional question: “From which Italian region are you?”. This question not only failed to add value to the analysis but was not even used. Another example is the question “How far would you be willing to travel for a weekend getaway?”, which aimed to assess the distance that respondents were willing to travel over a weekend. The main issue here was that the question assumed a short trip, thereby excluding the possibility of longer journeys, and again it did not add meaningful value due to its specificity. Another limitation of this survey was that most questions did not allow for a deeper exploration of attributes. Although there were questions designed to obtain a good description of each cluster, they failed to provide further insight into the rationale behind the order in which respondents ranked the attributes. Additionally, some of the collected data appeared rather noisy, which complicated the possibility of deriving robust clusters. For instance, repeated applications of clustering validation techniques (such as `KElbowVisualizer`) yielded unstable and inconsistent results, suggesting that the attributes were not sufficiently discriminative. This issue was further amplified by the role of respondents’ imagination: answers could vary depending on who planned the trip, the season, or the travel companions, which are factors that were not controlled in the survey.

Following the online survey, several questions related to Van Westendorp’s Price Sensitivity Meter, explained in detail in chapter 3, were included. These questions targeted very specific cases, such as the Quintana event, the Ascoliva Festival, a wine tasting, and a city tour. However, the model is designed to estimate willingness to pay for a representative product within the target market. [13]. A more appropriate approach would have been to formulate a single, general question referring to a typical tourist package, in order to obtain results that are more representative and comparable.

Fourth, the project was conducted as a group assignment, mainly during the winter break, which created challenges in terms of coordination. Each member faced different personal contexts: some were engaged with other courses and examinations, while others were travelling to their home countries. As a result, finding common times for meetings was often difficult, and the overall progress of the work advanced more slowly than expected.

Last but not least, the survey was written exclusively in English, which excluded some potential respondents who spoke Spanish, the third most widely spoken language in the world and commonly used across many regions. Although English is often regarded as a universal language, providing a Spanish version could

have increased participation, particularly among older individuals less familiar with English. This would have enriched the dataset by incorporating perspectives from a group that may have distinct travel behaviours and preferences.

In summary, while the original project successfully met the requirements of the course and provided an initial exploration of the research topic, these limitations constrained the depth, precision, and representativeness of its findings. The present thesis builds upon that foundation, addressing them through a more extensive working time period, improved qualitative methods, a refined survey design, and a larger and more diverse sample.

Chapter 2

Literature Review

This chapter reviews the main literature that supports and informs this research. It presents studies that explain the main ideas, theories, and methods relevant to this work. The goal is to show what other researchers have already done and to provide the methodological foundations for the work done in this study.

The review begins with a discussion of qualitative and quantitative research approaches, including their strengths and weaknesses. It then examines important models and methods used in tourism research, such as destination image formation, segmentation techniques, discrete choice experiments, and conjoint analysis. Issues such as response-style effects and hypothetical bias are also discussed, as they affect the quality of results. Finally, the chapter highlights studies that focus on tourist heterogeneity and the links between travel decisions.

2.1 Qualitative Approach

The qualitative approach relies on non-numerical evidence to generate insights and draw conclusions [17]. Such conclusions are based on rich, descriptive data, including words, narrative and observations, often referred to as “soft” data [18]. This method is particularly suited to the in-depth exploration of a topic and is commonly employed to understand how individuals experience and interpret the world [19]. It allows the identification of previously unknown processes, provides explanations of why and how phenomena occur, and reveals the range of their effects [16]. In this approach, the researcher seeks to interpret situations without imposing pre-existing assumptions or expectations on the phenomenon or setting under investigation [20].

The literature also highlights several potential risks that should be considered and mitigated:

1. Compliance bias: refers to situations in which participants' responses may be influenced by their perception of what they believe is expected of them [34].
2. Offset bias: occurs when participants are encouraged to reflect on issues they had not previously considered or to perceive certain topics as more complex than they would under normal circumstances [34].
3. Speculation bias: arises when participants are asked to predict their own behaviour in hypothetical future scenarios. Research suggests that individuals are generally not accurate in forecasting their actions in situations they have never experienced [34].

2.1.1 Advantages of Qualitative Approach

The qualitative approach seeks to preserve the voice and perspective of participants and can be adapted as new research questions emerge [19]. It is characterised by flexible design, which allows the researcher to experiment with different techniques to determine what is most effective within the context of the project [21]. Furthermore, it is typically conducted in natural settings, where data collection takes place in real-world contexts or in ways that closely mirror participants' everyday environments. This facilitates the gathering of meaningful insights by listening to detailed descriptions of people's experiences, feelings, and opinions. Such information can help improve the design, testing, or development of systems, services, or products. In addition, using open-ended questions and flexible approaches makes it easier to come up with new ideas and discover problems or opportunities that were not expected at the start of the study [19].

2.1.2 Disadvantages of Qualitative Approach

On the other hand, qualitative research has several limitations. First, its real-world setting can make findings less reliable because many factors influencing the data cannot be controlled. Second, the strong role of the researcher in interpreting results introduces subjectivity, meaning the same data could be analysed differently by different people and the study cannot be exactly replicated [19]. This reinforces the long-standing criticism that qualitative research findings are not verifiable, and verifiability, the principle that empirical investigations should be capable of replication so that their findings can be confirmed or refuted, is a central tenet of scientific research. It is difficult to replicate qualitative studies in the same way as quantitative ones; however, this does not mean that qualitative

research entirely lacks verifiability [22]. This is why it is important for the researcher to carefully document each step of the process, thereby creating an audit trail that allows other researchers to trace and review the original procedures if needed [23]. Third, the use of small samples limits the extent to which results can be generalised to a broader population, even when the analysis is rigorous [19]. This criticism may not be entirely justified, as the generalisability of results to an entire population is rarely the primary objective of the qualitative research approach [24]. Finally, qualitative research can be labour-intensive, as the review and interpretation of large amounts of textual data often require manual checking, despite the availability of software tools to assist with the process [19].

2.2 Quantitative Approach

The quantitative approach is defined as a research strategy that relies primarily on numerical evidence to draw conclusions [25]. Because of its focus on measurement and statistical analysis, it has often been described as a “hard” or “number-crunching” approach to research [26]. This approach involves the systematic collection and analysis of numerical data in order to identify patterns and averages, test relationships between variables, make predictions, and, when appropriate, generalise results to larger populations. It can be applied in various forms, including descriptive research, which summarises characteristics of variables; correlational research, which explores relationships between variables; and experimental research, which examines cause-and-effect links under controlled conditions. Data collection methods range from surveys and structured observations to experiments and secondary data analysis, all of which require clear operational definitions to translate abstract concepts into measurable indicators. Once collected, the data are processed and subjected to statistical analysis to answer the research questions and test the hypotheses [27].

2.2.1 Advantages of Quantitative Approach

The quantitative research offers several advantages, particularly in terms of standardisation and the potential to generalise findings to broader populations. One of its key strengths is replication, as the use of standardised data collection procedures and tangible definitions of abstract concepts allows studies to be repeated under similar conditions. This also facilitates direct comparisons of results, enabling research to be reproduced across different cultural contexts, time periods, or participant groups, with outcomes compared statistically. The accuracy of these measurement tools, such as questionnaires, can be strengthened by testing their

reliability using objective measures prior to data collection [29]. Furthermore, the approach is also well-suited to working with large samples, as quantitative data can be processed and analysed through consistent and reliable statistical procedures [27]. The knowledge gained from this group or subset of the population is representative of the entire population under study [28]. Finally, an additional advantage of the quantitative approach is that it is generally considered as a relatively impersonal method of conducting research, which helps to minimise the influence of the researcher’s personal biases on the outcomes of the study [30].

2.2.2 Disadvantages of Quantitative Approach

Despite its strengths, quantitative research also has its own limitations. One of them is superficiality, as the use of precise and restrictive operational definitions may inadequately represent complex concepts. For example, an abstract notion such as “mood” may be represented by a single numerical score, whereas qualitative research could provide a richer explanation. A narrow focus can also be an issue, since predetermined variables and measurement procedures may lead to the omission of other relevant observations. Moreover, even with standardised procedures, structural bias can occur due to factors such as missing data, imprecise measurements, or inappropriate sampling methods, which may distort the findings [27]. Finally, the quantitative approach can be relatively inflexible, as there is little a researcher can do after discovering an error in the data collection instrument. For instance, a question that is ambiguous or has been misinterpreted [31].

2.3 Model of Destination Image Formation

Baloglu and McCleary’s (1999) study is one of the most influential contributions to destination image research, offering both a conceptual framework and empirical evidence on how such images are formed. Their model shifts the focus from static descriptions of image, which dominated earlier studies, to the dynamic process through which potential tourists develop perceptions and impressions of destinations, particularly when they have not previously visited. They propose that destination image is a multi-dimensional construct composed of cognitive, affective, and global components. The cognitive or perceptual dimension reflects an individual’s knowledge and beliefs about a destination’s attributes—such as infrastructure, safety, cultural attractions, and value for money. The affective dimension refers to the emotional responses a destination evokes, such as whether it feels pleasant, exciting, or relaxing. Together, these components shape the overall

image, which ultimately guides destination choice [35].

Destination image arises from two broad forces: stimulus factors and personal factors. Stimulus factors include external influences such as marketing communications, media portrayals, word-of-mouth, and prior experience. Personal factors, in contrast, are characteristics of the perceiver, covering sociodemographic attributes like age and education as well as socio-psychological travel motivations, such as the desire for relaxation, excitement, knowledge, social interaction, or prestige. When individuals have not yet visited a destination, three determinants are particularly important in shaping image: tourism motivations, sociodemographic characteristics, and information sources. In their model, as shown in Figure 2.1, information sources act as stimulus variables, while motivations and sociodemographics represent personal characteristics [35].

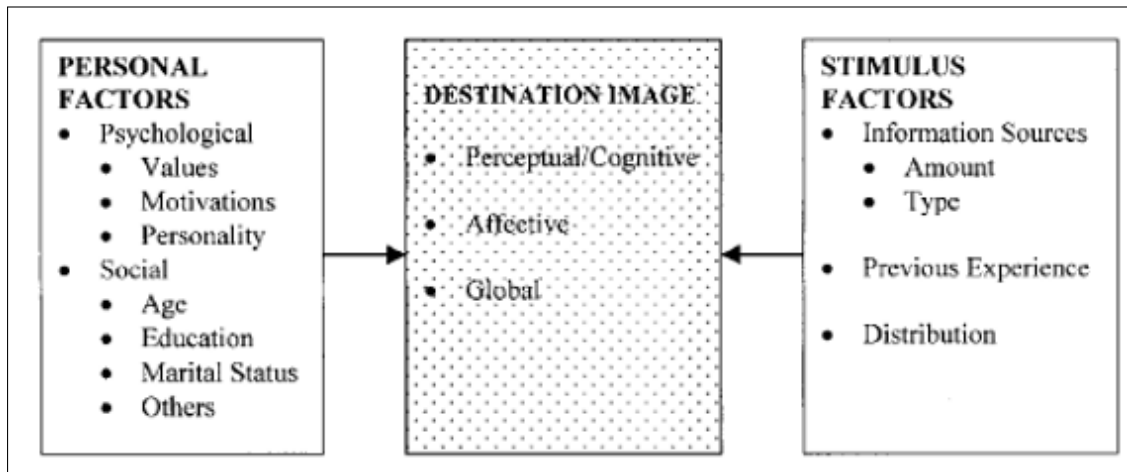


Figure 2.1: *A General Framework of Destination Image Formation. Source: Baloglu and McCleary's (1999).*

To test these propositions, Baloglu and McCleary developed a path model that hypothesized causal relationships among these variables. They predicted that cognitive evaluations would significantly influence affective ones, and that both dimensions would in turn affect overall image, with affect expected to carry the stronger impact. They also proposed that the variety and type of information sources, along with age and education, would affect cognitive evaluations, while motivations would directly influence affective responses. In total, eight hypotheses were tested through path analysis, using survey data from 448 potential tourists evaluating four Mediterranean destinations (Turkey, Greece, Italy, and Egypt) [35].

The findings strongly supported the proposed model. Cognitive evaluations emerged as significant predictors of affective responses, with “quality of experience” standing out as the most powerful cognitive factor shaping emotions. Affective evaluations, in turn, had the strongest direct effect on overall image, underscoring their mediating role. The study also revealed that the variety of informa-

tion sources used positively influenced cognitive evaluations, while word-of-mouth proved to be the single most powerful information source. Age and education, however, showed a negative influence on cognitive evaluations, with older and more educated respondents assessing destination attributes less positively. Motivations played a weaker role overall, with only relaxation and escape motives showing a significant—though negative—relationship with affect [35].

The study carries important implications for both theory and practice. Theoretically, it provides understanding of destination image by integrating cognitive and affective components into a single causal framework, showing the process to be dynamic and multi-dimensional. Practically, it reaffirms the central role of information sources, particularly word-of-mouth, in shaping perceptions, suggesting that destinations should invest in strategies that foster the sharing of positive experiences. Because motivations such as knowledge, prestige, and social interaction also influence image, marketers can adapt campaigns to tap into these psychological drivers. Finally, the negative relationship between age, education, and cognitive evaluations emphasize the need for targeted communication strategies that speak differently to diverse demographic groups. In essence, Baloglu and McCleary’s work demonstrates that destination image is co-created by external stimuli and personal characteristics, with affective responses serving as the critical bridge between cognition and overall impression [35].

2.4 Segmentation and Response-Style Effects

Pesonen and Honkanen (2014) examine how tourists’ response styles can influence segmentation outcomes when applying k-means cluster analysis. A response style refers to the tendency of individuals to answer questionnaires in a systematic way that is unrelated to the actual content. For example, consistently giving high or low ratings, or avoiding the extremes of a scale. These patterns, known as response-style effects, can significantly distort cluster solutions by grouping individuals based on their answering habits rather than their true motivations or attitudes. Since segmentation aims to form clusters that are internally homogenous and externally distinct, ignoring response styles may lead to producing segments that are artificial and unhelpful for marketing purposes [36].

The authors note that cluster analysis, particularly k-means, remains the most widely used technique in tourism segmentation research. However, this approach is highly sensitive to response styles. Past research has sometimes produced clusters resembling “want-it-all” tourists who rate everything highly, or “passive” tourists who rate everything poorly, patterns that may reflect answering tendencies rather than meaningful market segments. Such results challenge the practical utility of

segmentation for identifying actionable strategies [36].

To investigate this issue, the authors collected data via an online survey hosted on a Finnish cottage holiday website. Respondents rated 31 travel motivation items on a 7-point Likert scale. After data cleaning, 709 responses were retained, of which 25 motivation items were used for segmentation. The researchers applied k-means cluster analysis to four versions of the dataset [36]:

1. The original unstandardized data.
2. Data adjusted to remove acquiescence response style (ARS) through within-case standardization (row-centering), which highlights relative item importance per respondent.
3. Data adjusted to remove extreme response style (ERS) by dividing responses by each individual's standard deviation.
4. Data with both ARS and ERS removed.

The results revealed marked differences across the cluster solutions. Using the original data, the clusters largely mirrored response styles: some groups scored consistently high, others low, and some in the middle. This confirmed that k-means was capturing answering patterns rather than motivational differences. Once ARS was removed, however, the clusters displayed distinct motivational profiles, with respondents prioritizing certain travel motives over others. This approach produced more interpretable and actionable segmentations. By contrast, removing only ERS offered little improvement, as the clustering still reflected broad high–low patterns. When both ARS and ERS were removed, the solution resembled the ARS-only result, suggesting that acquiescence was the dominant factor influencing clustering [36].

The study emphasizes the methodological importance of addressing response-style bias in tourism segmentation studies. Without accounting for these effects, researchers risk generating misleading clusters that do not represent real market segments. Pesonen and Honkanen conclude that correcting for ARS yields the most meaningful results in this case, and they stress the need for segmentation studies to explicitly report how response styles are handled. They further recommend that future research explore alternative segmentation methods and use simulated data to deepen understanding of how response styles shape clustering outcomes [36].

2.5 Discrete Choice Experiments in Tourism

Kemperman (2021) provides a comprehensive review of the use of discrete choice experiments (DCEs) in tourism, analyzing 49 studies published between

2010 and 2020 in the five leading tourism journals. DCEs are widely employed to measure and predict preferences by presenting individuals with alternatives that vary in their attributes. This approach allows researchers to estimate the relative importance of different destination, product, or service features and to calculate willingness to pay for specific attributes. In tourism, DCEs have been applied to questions such as destination choice, travel mode, accommodation type, and activity selection [37].

The method is rooted in random utility theory, which assumes that individuals choose the option that maximizes their utility. Utility consists of a systematic component, based on observable attributes, and a random component that captures unobserved factors. In tourism, this means that travelers are assumed to select the destination, activity, or service that provides the highest perceived benefit given their motivations and constraints. By putting together destinations or services as bundles of attributes such as price, quality, amenities, and location, and asking respondents to choose between hypothetical alternatives, researchers can estimate the marginal utility of each attribute [37].

DCEs can use both revealed and stated choice data. Revealed data come from actual behavior such as bookings, while stated data are gathered in controlled experiments. The former reflects real-world decisions, whereas the latter allows researchers to anticipate preferences for products or services that do not yet exist. In practice, when market data are unavailable or lack variation, stated choice experiments often provide the only viable means of capturing likely behavior [37].

A key strength of DCEs is their ability to simulate decision-making in a structured way. Tourists are presented with multiple choice scenarios in which attributes vary systematically, allowing researchers to isolate the impact of each factor. This design provides high internal validity, though external validity can be more limited since the choices are hypothetical. Kemperman’s review shows that most studies still examine single, independent decisions but relatively few investigate linked or sequential decisions, such as destination, transport, and accommodation together. In reality, these choices are interdependent [37].

Kemperman (2021) shows that discrete choice experiments provide a powerful lens for understanding tourist preferences and predicting responses to innovations in tourism products and services. She argues that future research should design more realistic experiments, incorporate dynamic needs and social influences, and make use of emerging tools such as virtual reality and eye-tracking to enhance engagement and data quality. Such advancements would extend DCEs beyond predicting what choices tourists make toward offering richer insights into how and why those choices are made [37].

2.6 Conjoint Analysis in Tourism

Altin (2023) offers a comprehensive overview of how conjoint analysis has been applied in tourism research as a method for measuring tourist preferences. Conjoint analysis is a choice-based technique that allows researchers to understand how travelers value different attributes of destinations, services, or experiences. By decomposing a tourism product into key elements, such as price, accommodation type, attractions, or amenities, it estimates the value respondents assign to each attribute. This makes it possible to capture the trade-offs travelers are willing to make when choosing between alternatives, providing useful insights for destination management organizations (DMOs), tour operators, and other industry stakeholders seeking to design competitive offerings [38].

Methodologically, conjoint analysis involves presenting respondents with sets of hypothetical profiles or “bundles” that combine different attribute levels. Respondents are asked to select their preferred option from each set. Statistical analysis of these choices produces utilities and relative importance estimates for each attribute, showing which features drive satisfaction and willingness to pay (WTP). In tourism, this approach has been applied to diverse products such as destination packages, activity mixes, accommodation types, and other experience-based offerings. Given that tourism products are typically multi-attribute in nature, conjoint analysis provides a structured way to reflect their combined influence on decision-making [38].

Altin (2023) [38] also highlights the practical advantages of conjoint analysis for industry practitioners. Well-designed studies can guide product development and market positioning by identifying which attributes matter most to particular traveler segments. By simulating realistic decision-making, conjoint analysis also supports market segmentation, differentiation, and competitive benchmarking, which are critical in a crowded and highly competitive industry [38].

The author also describes several considerations and challenges in applying conjoint analysis. First, the careful selection of attributes is essential: including too many risks overwhelming respondents, whereas omitting key features may reduce validity. Second, samples must be sufficiently representative to ensure generalizable results. Altin further notes the growing relevance of digital and adaptive conjoint approaches, which ease data collection and allow more flexible, personalized designs. As tourism evolves toward increasing complexity, through sustainability concerns, digital innovations, and shifting traveler expectations, conjoint analysis continues to adapt in order to capture these new dimensions of tourist choice [38].

Altin’s work serves as a methodological anchor in tourism research by demonstrating the value of conjoint analysis for understanding preferences, informing

product design, and supporting strategic decisions at both managerial and policy levels. By linking conjoint studies with broader frameworks of tourism behavior, this contribution provides a roadmap for integrating preference modeling into the study of tourist decision-making [38].

2.7 Hypothetical Bias

Hensher (2010) reviews how hypothetical bias affects willingness-to-pay (WTP) estimates derived from stated preference (SP) methods and discrete choice experiments (DCEs). Hypothetical bias arises from discrepancies between what people report they would choose or pay in surveys, and what they actually do in real-world situations. Since SP and DCE studies typically lack financial consequences, respondents may overstate their preferences or WTP, often producing inflated values. This poses a serious challenge in transport, environmental, and tourism research, where WTP estimates are commonly used to justify policies and investments [39].

The paper synthesizes evidence comparing WTP from hypothetical surveys with values obtained from revealed preference (RP) studies or actual market behavior. Some studies detect no difference, while others find that WTP from SP and DCEs tends to be much lower than real-market values. Hensher (2010) [39] argues that no single factor explains this variation and that outcomes depend on the type of good, survey design, and respondents' familiarity with the decision context [39].

To mitigate hypothetical bias, several strategies are discussed. One is anchoring surveys in real experiences, for example by “pivoting” choice sets around respondents' existing travel habits. This grounds choices in familiar conditions, and narrows the gap between hypothetical and real decisions. Other techniques include adding opt-out alternatives, using “cheap-talk” scripts that warn about overstatement, or providing consequentiality scripts and honesty oaths to increase the perceived importance of responses. While these tools have shown promise, their effectiveness is context-dependent [39].

The author also highlights the role of calibration methods. Ex ante approaches (instrument-based) seek to prevent bias during survey design, while ex post techniques (statistical adjustments) correct results after data collection using confidence ratings or benchmark comparisons. For instance, calibration functions derived from observed market data have been applied to adjust WTP values, producing results more consistent with revealed behavior [39].

A key contribution of the paper is its emphasis on reference alternatives in DCEs. Anchoring choice tasks to respondents' actual experiences, rather than

purely hypothetical scenarios, was shown to reduce bias. Case studies in Australia and New Zealand demonstrated that mean values of travel time savings (VTTS) were significantly higher and more realistic when based on a reference commute compared to forced-choice scenarios. This suggests that reference-dependent designs yield WTP estimates that are more reliable for policy analysis [39].

Hensher (2010) [39] concludes that no universal remedy exists for hypothetical bias. Instead, researchers should use a combination of careful survey design, calibration techniques, and validation against real behavior. The paper highlights the need for further research into hybrid data approaches and pivot-based experiments, which show strong potential for narrowing the gap between hypothetical and real-world valuations [39].

2.8 Representing Tourists’ Heterogeneous Destination and Travel Party Choices

Wu, Zhang, and Fujiwara (2011) develop a modeling approach that jointly analyzes tourists’ choices of destination and travel party, recognizing that these decisions are interdependent and vary across individuals. Travel decisions are rarely made in isolation; the choice of destination often depends on who tourists travel with, and the composition of the travel party can influence destination selection. The authors argue that treating these choices separately, as prior studies often did, overlooks the sequential and interactive nature of travel decisions. Their paper addresses this by integrating a latent class model with a nested logit model to capture both the interdependency and heterogeneity in tourist decision-making [40].

The latent class model identifies unobserved tourist segments that follow different decision-making sequences. Some decide on a destination first, then their travel companions, while others choose their travel party before selecting a destination. Within each segment, the nested logit model reflects the sequential choice process based on random utility maximization. This combined approach allows distinguishing groups with distinct “decision hierarchies,” offering a more realistic representation of travel behavior [40].

The model uses survey data from over 2,000 tourists in Japan, covering 14 destination zones and three travel party categories: traveling alone, traveling with family, and traveling with friends or others. Variables influencing destination choice included travel time, destination attractiveness (measured by annual visitors), and number of tourist spots. Travel party choice was explained by gender, age, and marital status. Results showed all explanatory variables were statistically signif-

icant. Travel time had the strongest impact on destination choice, while marital status most strongly predicted travel party composition. Women and married individuals were more likely to travel with family or friends, whereas younger travelers leaned toward independent travel. Crucially, about half of tourists followed a decision sequence beginning with destination choice (latent class 1), while the other half started by selecting their travel party (latent class 2). This demonstrates the absence of a single dominant pattern and emphasizes the importance of modeling heterogeneity rather than assuming uniform behavior. The nested logit parameters confirmed significant interdependencies [40].

The authors conclude that this integrated latent class–nested logit model provides a more flexible and realistic framework for capturing tourist decision-making. For planners and marketers, the findings highlight the value of understanding destinations’ sensitivity to travel party structure, enabling more targeted promotions. The study also points to the importance of considering decision-making structures alongside sociodemographic segmentation. The authors suggest future research should expand the model to include additional decision dimensions, such as accommodation and travel mode choices, and test its applicability across cultural contexts [40].

Chapter 3

Methodology

Add an introduction to the chapter

3.1 Qualitative Interviews

3.1.1 The Interviews

The first step consisted of qualitative interviews, which were used to identify possible attributes related to tourist destinations. This was carried out through flexible open questions, mainly focusing on real-world experiences. Although flexible, a guide of predefined questions was created (see Figure 3.1) to provide a general structure for the interviews, while still leaving the possibility to deviate and follow the flow of each individual conversation. Each new interview generated additional ideas and opportunities that informed subsequent ones, thus enriching the insights obtained. Furthermore, all interviews were conducted online and recorded, and the corresponding transcriptions were produced (see Appendix B for an example), allowing the subsequent analysis to be validated against the original data.

For these interviews, the aim was to gather perspectives from individuals of different generations, nationalities, and professional backgrounds. The sample included:

- Sex: 8 males and 2 females
- Age: median of 26 years old, with a maximum equal to 41 years old, and a minimum equal to 21 years old.
- Nationalities: 5 Argentinians, 2 Spanish, 1 Italian, 1 Colombian, and 1 Iranian.

Main Questions	In-depth Questions
First, I'd like you to think about the last few times you went on vacation to a tourist destination. Can you walk me through the typical process you follow—from the moment you decide you want to travel until everything is planned?	• What do you consider when choosing the destination? • Do you look anywhere for help or inspiration? • How much time do you usually take for vacation?
Now, thinking about your last trip — was there anything you did differently from what you just described?	• If so, was the change for better or worse? • Why did you change or stop doing that?
Thinking about your recent trips, once you were at the destination, what did you do?	• Did you engage in any activities? • Was it a good experience? What did you like or dislike?
When it came time to eat, how did you decide where to go and what to eat?	• Was it the same for lunch and dinner? • Where did you search for places?
Before we finish, could you name a few of your most recent travel destinations?	• Which ones did you enjoy the most and the least? Why?
Finally, is there anything else you'd like to add or think is important to mention?	

If the interviewee feels comfortable: Please share your screen. Would you mind showing me how you would search for your next trip on your phone or computer, as if you were planning it right now?

Figure 3.1: *Guide for Qualitative Interview Questions. Source: Author's own elaboration*

- Occupations: 5 employed people and 5 Master's students (one of whom had worked for approximately 20 years before starting the degree).

The interviews were conducted through the Zoom platform and in the original language of each interviewee, allowing them to clearly and fully describe their real experiences. In cases where the interviewer and interviewee did not share the same mother tongue, English was used as the common language. Among all the interviews, the only one conducted in English was with the Iranian participant. Furthermore, all interviewees were informed about the recording process, with emphasis placed on the fact that no personal or sensitive information would be disclosed. The main objective at this stage was to understand the genuine process by which interviewees defined and prepared a trip. For this reason, participants were asked to share their screen (or, in cases where this was not possible, the interviewer shared the screen and followed the steps as described by the interviewee) and to demonstrate step by step how they organised either a past trip or an upcoming one. While describing their planning process, they showed the resources they used and expressed both positive and negative impressions. When needed, the interviewer intervened to ask additional questions in order to explore certain topics in greater depth. Nevertheless, the main goal was to allow the interviewee to speak as freely as possible, and as mentioned before, without introducing any potential bias.

After this initial block, in which participants described their real-life experiences of trip planning, they were asked specifically about Ascoli Piceno. In this section, they were invited to demonstrate how they would prepare for a hypothet-

ical trip to the city. They were asked to apply their usual, real-life trip planning process to the case of Ascoli Piceno, following the same steps, tools, and resources they normally use. The aim was to capture their genuine opinions about Ascoli Piceno and to identify potential attributes associated with it, both positive and negative. One of the most relevant aspects of this stage concerned their impressions when analysing the map and the geographical position of the city. In some cases, participants were also asked to compare Ascoli Piceno with Pistoia, a city of similar characteristics located near Florence. At this point, further attributes emerged, particularly when interviewees were asked to decide whether they would prefer to visit one city over the other, and to explain their reasons.

Finally, they were introduced to specific topics related to Ascoli Piceno, such as the olive ascolane and the Quintana festival, in order to gather insights about attributes associated with local events and cultural traditions. At the end of the interview, participants were given the opportunity to add any further comments, which often provided additional perspectives or reinforced the main points that had emerged throughout the session.

3.1.2 The Transcriptions

After all interviews were completed, the transcription cleaning process was carried out. For the first two interviews, since the automatic transcription feature had not been enabled, the audio files were transcribed in Google Colab using **WhisperX**, an enhanced transcription tool built on OpenAI’s Whisper that incorporates speaker diarization from Hugging Face to provide more accurate transcripts and speaker separation [33]. Once the raw transcriptions were obtained (either from Google Colab or Zoom), a manual verification process was conducted. During this stage, the transcripts were checked against the recordings and corrected where necessary, particularly in cases where words or phrases had been inaccurately transcribed. Finally, ChatGPT was used carefully to efficiently translate each transcription into English. Following this, each transcription was carefully re-read, with notes taken on the most relevant insights and linked to potential attributes. This process was repeated for every interview, highlighting key phrases and extracting attributes to inform the quantitative survey.

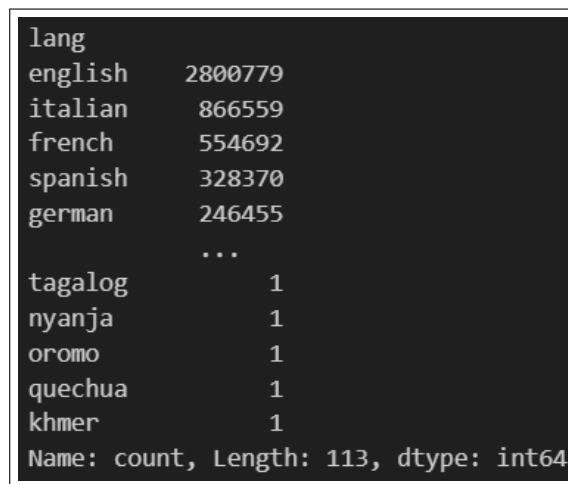
Once this analysis was completed, all unique attributes were compiled in an Excel sheet together with their corresponding frequency. Frequency was defined as the number of interviews in which a given attribute appeared, with a maximum possible frequency of 10 (equal to the total number of interviews).

3.2 Textual Analysis of Online Accommodation Reviews

3.2.1 Airbnb

One of the datasets used for this analysis consisted of Airbnb reviews from various Italian cities. These data were obtained from the Inside Airbnb platform, which provides quarterly datasets for multiple regions and cities available for free download [42]. The Italian cities included in this analysis were Bergamo, Bologna, Florence, Milan, Naples, Puglia, Rome, Sicily, Trentino, and Venice. All individual datasets were concatenated into a single dataset, resulting in a total of 7,141,844 records. The dataset contained the following variables: `listing_id`, `id`, `date`, `reviewer_id`, `reviewer_name`, `comments`, and `location`.

To optimise computational performance, a word count was calculated for each review, and only reviews up to the upper quartile (75%) of this distribution were retained. This filtering step reduced the dataset to 5,383,460 records. Since reviews were written in multiple languages, a language detection process was implemented using the Compact Language Detector 2 (`clld2`), which probabilistically detects over 80 languages in UTF-8 encoded text [43]. To ensure consistency in the subsequent text-mining process, only English-language reviews were retained, resulting in 2,800,779 entries (see Figure 3.2). To further optimise computational efficiency, a random 15% sample of the English reviews was used in the final analysis.



lang	
english	2800779
italian	866559
french	554692
spanish	328370
german	246455
...	
tagalog	1
nyanja	1
oromo	1
quechua	1
khmer	1
Name: count, Length: 113, dtype: int64	

Figure 3.2: *Compact Language Detector 2 Results.* Source: Author’s own elaboration based on *Inside Airbnb*

The remaining reviews were tokenised into individual words using the `word_tokenize` function from the NLTK library. All tokens were converted to lowercase to maintain consistency and reduce redundancy caused by case differences. Stopwords

and punctuation marks were then removed using the NLTK English stopwords list and the `string` library, respectively. A custom cleaning function was applied to remove both types of noise, leaving only meaningful tokens. Subsequently, all words were lemmatised using the `spaCy` library to reduce them to their base or dictionary form (e.g., “running” → “run”). To optimise performance, texts were processed in batches of 2,000 using parallelisation across four cores. The cleaned and lemmatised tokens were then stored as a new variable in the dataset, producing a standardised textual representation suitable for further computational analysis, such as topic modelling and sentiment classification.

Following text preprocessing, the cleaned tokens were converted into numerical features using the Term Frequency–Inverse Document Frequency (TF–IDF) method, implemented through the `TfidfVectorizer` from the `scikit-learn` library. This approach quantifies the relative importance of each term across the collection of reviews, balancing its frequency within a document against its occurrence across all documents. Both unigrams (single words) and trigrams (three-word sequences) were extracted using the following configuration parameters:

- `lowercase=False`: case sensitivity was preserved, as tokens had already been normalized before this step.
- `token_pattern=r"(?u)\b\w+\b"`: ensured that only alphanumeric tokens were included.
- `ngram_range=(x,y)`: defines the minimum (x) and maximum (y) size of n-grams to include in the analysis. In this study, unigrams (1,1) and trigrams (3,3) were used.
- `min_df=5`: excluded words appearing in fewer than five reviews to reduce noise.
- `max_df=0.8`: excluded terms present in more than 80% of reviews, filtering out overly common words.
- `max_features=100,000`: restricted the feature space to the most informative terms.

The TF–IDF scores were aggregated across all documents to obtain a global measure of each term’s relative importance. To visualise the most relevant words in the corpus, a word cloud was generated using the `WordCloud` library, where word size corresponds to cumulative TF–IDF scores. Additionally, the top 20 terms were identified and presented in tabular form, ranked by their total TF–IDF weight.

3.2.2 Booking.com

The Booking.com Reviews Dataset is a comprehensive collection of hotel reviews and ratings gathered from the popular travel booking platform, Booking.com. This dataset provides valuable insights into customers' experiences and perceptions of hotels across various destinations [41]. After importing the dataset, reviews containing the text "There are no comments available for this review" were removed, leaving a total of 18,988 valid records for analysis.

Each review was tokenised using the `word_tokenize` function from the NLTK library, and all tokens were converted to lowercase to ensure consistency. As in the Airbnb pipeline, stopwords (from NLTK's English stopword list) and punctuation marks (from Python's `string` library) were removed to retain only semantically meaningful words. The resulting tokens were then lemmatised using the `spacy` language model, reducing each word to its base form and consolidating morphological variants (e.g., "rooms" $\rightarrow$ "room"). A final cleaning step was applied to remove generic or low-information terms such as "review" and "comment."

After preprocessing, the dataset was divided into two subsets based on the rating score:

- Positive reviews: ratings ≥ 7
- Negative reviews: ratings < 7

For each subset (positive and negative), a TF-IDF vectoriser was applied to transform the lemmatised text into a numerical representation. The configuration parameters used were as follows:

- `lowercase=False`: case sensitivity was preserved, as tokens had already been normalized before this step.
- `token_pattern=r"(?u)\b\w+\b"`: ensured that only alphanumeric tokens were included.
- `ngram_range=(x,y)`: defines the minimum (x) and maximum (y) size of n-grams to include in the analysis. In this study, unigrams (1,1) and trigrams (3,3) were used.
- `min_df=5`: excluded words appearing in fewer than five reviews to reduce noise.
- `max_df=0.8`: excluded terms present in more than 80% of reviews, filtering out overly common words.

- `max_features=100,000`: restricted the feature space to the most informative terms.

The resulting TF-IDF matrices were aggregated to identify the most relevant terms within positive and negative reviews. To visualise these patterns, word clouds were generated, with word size proportional to cumulative TF-IDF scores. Additionally, the top 20 terms were extracted and presented in tabular form for each subset, offering a clear comparison of the dominant lexical features that distinguish positive and negative customer experiences.

3.3 Explanatory Survey

To further advance the analysis, an explanatory survey (see Appendix E) was conducted using Microsoft Forms to capture travelers’ perceptions, decision-making processes, and experiences related to tourism. The survey was available in both English and Spanish and distributed to 25 respondents without disclosing the specific research purpose. Data collection concluded once all 25 responses had been received. This stage functioned as a bridge between the qualitative interviews and the final quantitative survey, serving both to test question clarity and to generate additional insights for refining the set of destination attributes.

The survey combined open-ended and structured questions. The open-ended questions invited respondents to narrate personal travel experiences (e.g., unsatisfactory trips, representative vacations, or memorable journeys) and to offer advice to their “past self” regarding travel decision-making. Scenario-based questions (scene choices) were also included to explore how travelers evaluate different destination settings. The structured questions focused on decision-making steps, missing factors in information searches, levels of information saturation, and perceptions of pricing. For the latter, a question based on Van Westendorp’s Price Sensitivity Meter was included to estimate acceptable price ranges for a tourism package. This model offers a comprehensive multi-question framework that indirectly measures willingness to pay, identifying a range of acceptable prices rather than a single point estimate [44].

Once collected, responses in Spanish were translated into English using ChatGPT, followed by careful manual verification to ensure accuracy. The dataset was then imported into Google Colab for processing, where column names were standardised. An exploratory data analysis (EDA) was conducted to summarise key statistics and visualise general respondent characteristics. For the Van Westendorp model, inconsistent responses, such as cases in which the “too cheap” value exceeded the “bargain” value, were removed. Outliers were excluded using

the interquartile range thresholds ($Q1 - 1.5 \times IQR$ and $Q3 + 1.5 \times IQR$). This procedure enabled the estimation of price thresholds for “too cheap,” “bargain,” “expensive,” and “too expensive,” ultimately identifying the Optimal Price Point (OPP).

The textual responses were processed using a standardised natural language preprocessing pipeline, which included:

- Conversion of text to lowercase.
- Removal of punctuation, special characters, and extra spaces.
- Normalisation of accented characters.
- Tokenisation and lemmatisation using `spaCy`.
- Stopword removal to retain only meaningful terms.

The analysis followed a text-mining approach combining semantic and frequency-based techniques. Sentence embeddings (using `SentenceTransformers`) were employed to capture semantic similarity and group related responses, with cosine similarity calculated through the `networkx` library. TF-IDF vectorisation was subsequently applied within each semantic cluster to identify the most frequent words and expressions. Sentence embeddings were first used to group responses, followed by TF-IDF analysis within each group, for the following open-ended questions:

- “Tell us about a trip of yours that you were not satisfied with. What would you not do again, especially in the planning phase?” (similarity fixed greater than 0.7).
- “Which trip or vacation best represents your way of choosing how to travel? Tell us about the destination: how you chose it, why it reflects you, etc” (similarity fixed greater than 0.67).
- “If you had to teach someone your method of choosing, which 3 fundamental steps would you tell them to follow?” (similarity fixed greater than 0.7).
- “If instead you had to give 3 pieces of advice to your past self about organising a vacation, what would you say?” (similarity fixed greater than 0.7).
- “When you organised your last vacation, did you have a list of destinations in mind? How did you make your final choice? And among them, was there a destination you said, ‘No, this is not for me’?” (similarity fixed greater than 0.7).

For other questions, only TF-IDF vectorisation was applied, using different n-gram configurations depending on the length and structure of responses:

- “Imagine organising a vacation. Sketch a short story of your choice: what would be the 3–4 main scenes?”
- “Which was the decisive piece of information you looked at last before choosing?”
- “When did you feel you had ‘enough’ information to decide? What made you stop searching? And if you had had more time, what would you have added to your research?”
- “What type of trip do you usually choose: a short trip, a medium-length trip, or a long one? Please explain the reason for your choice.”

In some cases, additional steps were taken prior to text analysis. For the question “Which was the decisive piece of information you looked at last before choosing?”, responses were divided into two groups (A and B) according to the answer to the preceding question, “If you had to choose right now, which of the two screens would you pick?”. For the question “What type of trip do you usually choose: a short trip, a medium-length trip, or a long one? Please explain the reason for your choice”, responses were manually labelled based on the preferred trip length (short, medium, long, or not defined). Finally, for the questions “If you had to teach someone your method of choosing, which 3 fundamental steps would you tell them to follow?” and “If instead you had to give 3 pieces of advice to your past self about organising a vacation, what would you say?”, all steps were concatenated for each case, preserving their order, so that each respondent’s full set of steps or pieces of advice could be analysed as a single continuous text.

Chapter 4

Results

Introduction of this chapter.

4.1 Qualitative Interviews

After the interview transcriptions were properly cleaned, the main insights were extracted from each case. Some phrases contained a single attribute, while others referred to multiple ones. For instance, in the first interview with the Italian respondent, he said: "...in that famous Tuscany trip, we also included the Palio di Siena...". This was linked to a general attribute: local events. On the other hand, in the second interview with an Argentinian respondent, he said: "...we looked a lot into what the transportation is like there, food prices, which beaches are recommended.". In this case, the phrase was related to three attributes: public transportation, food prices, and beaches. These initial attributes were not definitive but rather a starting point. All detailed notes from each interview are available in Appendix C.

Based on these notes, the frequency of each attribute was calculated. As shown in Figure 4.1, the top attributes appeared in 6 to 9 interviews. From this, the eight most frequent attributes were initially selected as the final ones. However, a small adjustment was made to ensure topic diversity: the 7th attribute (accommodation price) was excluded because the 1st attribute already referred to accommodation type, and the 8th attribute (distance to reach the destination) was excluded because the 6th attribute already addressed cost to reach the destination.

Finally, after a visit to Ascoli Piceno, the initial list of attributes was refined to improve their accuracy and clarity. Some attribute names were adjusted to avoid ambiguity or misinterpretation, and a few new ones were added based on observations during the visit. The final set of attributes included:

- Accommodation type.

#	Attribute	Frequency
1	accommodation type	9
2	online recommendations	9
3	proximity to other destinations	9
4	local cuisine	8
5	accessibility to touristic points	7
6	cost to reach	7
7	accommodation price	6
8	distance to reach	6
9	historical buildings	6
10	local events	6

Figure 4.1: *Preliminary Top 10 Attributes by Frequency. Source: Author’s own elaboration*

- Online recommendations.
- Proximity to other touristic destinations.
- Local traditional cuisine (the word traditional was added to emphasise the focus on local food).
- Availability of tourist attractions at the destination (the attribute “accessibility to touristic points” was discarded after the visit, as it was not considered accurate).
- Ease of reaching the destination, Cost to reach the destination (added to capture the trade-off between cost and ease of access noted during the visit).
- Historical architecture.
- Local events, and Proximity to the beach (added after observing Ascoli’s proximity to coastal areas such as San Benedetto del Tronto, and supported by interviewees who mentioned it as an important attribute).

4.2 Online Accommodation Reviews

After applying the TF-IDF method to the Airbnb dataset, the unigram analysis revealed that the most frequent terms were primarily related to the location of the property and the services offered by the accommodation. This suggests that, when writing reviews, guests tend to emphasise not only the geographical setting (e.g., location, walk, or close) but also the specific amenities provided (e.g., clean, comfortable, or amenity). As shown in Figure 4.2, these two dimensions—location and services—emerged as dominant topics shaping guests’ perceptions and experiences.

To gain a more detailed understanding, the same analysis was conducted using trigrams. As shown in Figure 4.3, the results further reinforced the centrality of



Figure 4.2: *Airbnb Reviews' Top Words.* Source: Author's own elaboration based on Inside Airbnb

location, with frequent expressions such as “place great location”, “great location close”, “within walking distance”, and “close train station”. In contrast, there were relatively few trigrams directly associated with services, and several of the most frequent ones still referred to location, such as “clean great location”. This indicates that, even when considering multi-word expressions, guests consistently prioritise aspects related to the property’s location over other features of the accommodation.



Figure 4.3: *Airbnb Reviews' Top 3-grams.* Source: Author's own elaboration based on Inside Airbnb

Turning to the Booking.com dataset, the unigram analysis of positive reviews revealed that the most frequent terms were again related to both the location of the property and the services provided by the accommodation. As shown in Figure 6.1 (see Appendix D), compared with the Airbnb reviews, a greater number

of terms referred to specific services such as “breakfast”, “reception”, “garden”, and “bed”. In addition, new location-related terms appeared, including “metro” and “restaurant”.

In contrast, the unigram analysis of negative reviews (see Figure 6.2 in Appendix D) showed that, although “location” remained a highly frequent term, a larger share of the most common words referred to accommodation services, including “shower”, “bathroom”, “bed”, and “staff”.

The trigram analysis of positive reviews (see Figure 4.4) highlighted the growing importance of accommodation services, with common expressions such as “friendly helpful staff” and “room comfortable bed”. Location, however, remained a crucial factor, with trigrams such as “within walking distance” and “close city center”.



Figure 4.4: *Booking.com Positive Reviews’ 3-grams. Source: Author’s own elaboration based on a Kaggle’s dataset*

As shown in Figure 4.5, the trigram analysis of negative reviews revealed a stronger emphasis on location, with expressions such as “close train station”, “5 minute walk”, and “close city center”. At the same time, several trigrams provided clearer insights into service-related concerns, including “4 star hotel”, “friendly helpful staff”, and “coffee make facility”.

Based on the insights obtained from the textual analyses of both datasets, the list of attributes was refined and improved as follows:

- Accommodation services: reviews frequently mentioned elements such as breakfast, room quality, staff, cleanliness, and shower facilities.
- Availability of centrally located accommodation: added as a new attribute, given that many reviews highlighted location; the word “centrally” provides a more precise segmentation.

aged over 60 was also identified. The majority of respondents were female and employed, with South America representing the most common region of origin. In terms of travel behaviour, participants typically organised trips collaboratively and tended to travel with companions such as partners, family, or friends. As shown in Figure 4.6, the primary motivation for travel was exploring new cities, although relaxation was also cited as a complementary purpose.

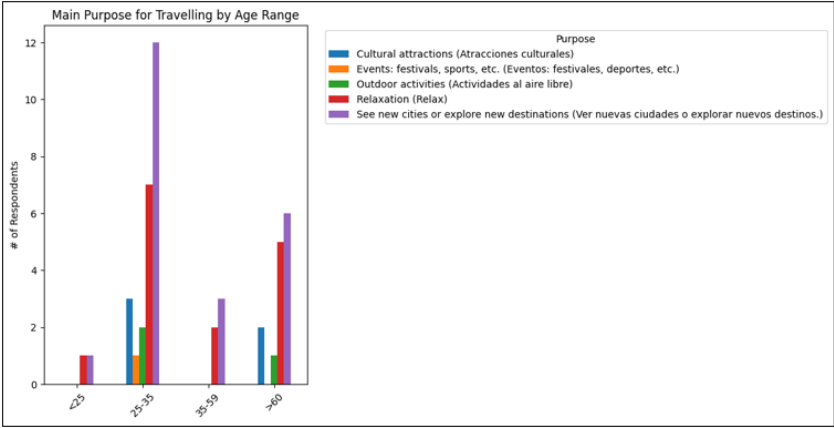


Figure 4.6: *Main Purpose for Travelling.* Source: Author’s own elaboration based on survey data.

Notable differences emerged across age groups: younger respondents reported relying primarily on Google or similar platforms—and in some cases ChatGPT—for information searches, whereas older respondents showed a stronger reliance on travel blogs or agencies. Regarding decision-making patterns, respondents generally reported considering three to four destination options and taking several days to evaluate alternatives before confirming their booking, as shown in Figure 4.7.

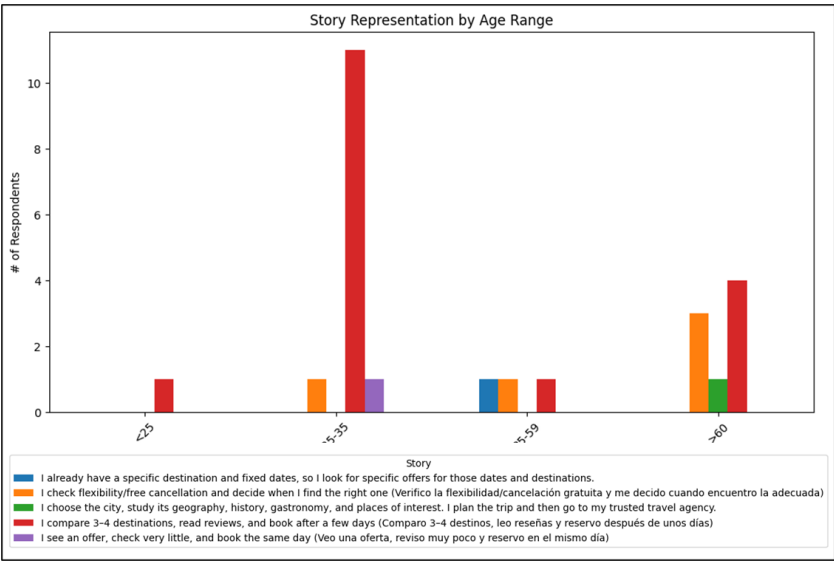


Figure 4.7: *Description of Explanatory Survey’s Respondents.* Source: Author’s own elaboration based on survey data.

4.3.2 Van Westendorp Price Sensitivity Analysis

The analysis of price perceptions using the Van Westendorp method revealed notable differences across age groups. For the full sample (see Figure 4.8), after removing outliers and inconsistent responses, the Optimal Price Point (OPP) was estimated at €250.06. When the analysis was segmented, clear differences emerged: respondents aged 35 or younger reported a substantially lower OPP of €150.20 (see Figure 6.5 in Appendix G), whereas those older than 35 years displayed a much higher OPP of €279.46 (see Figure ?? in Appendix G). For the latter group, outliers were retained, as their removal resulted in no definable OPP. These findings indicate that younger respondents demonstrate greater price sensitivity and a lower willingness to pay for tourism products, whereas older respondents are generally more willing to spend, suggesting distinct consumer profiles relevant for market segmentation and pricing strategies.

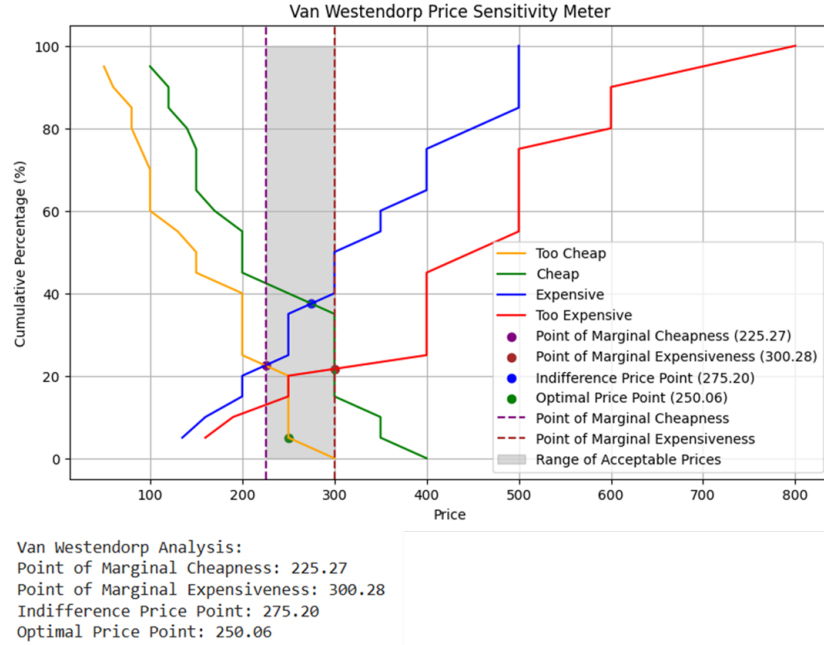


Figure 4.8: Van Westendorp Pricing Method with Full Sample. Source: Author's own elaboration based on survey data.

4.3.3 Text Mining, Embeddings & TF-IDF

Unsatisfying Trip

In response to the question “Tell us about a trip of yours that you were not satisfied with. What would you not do again, especially in the planning phase?”, two groups were identified. The first group (see Figure 4.9), composed mainly of young adults (25–35), emphasised poor organisation as the main reason for

dissatisfaction.

ID	bad_trip_story	age_group
2	Although the trip I did to Valencia, Spain, la...	25-35
6	I'm not entirely dissatisfied with my recent t...	25-35
12	It's not that there was a trip I didn't like, ...	25-35
13	The latest trip that I was not satisfied with ...	25-35
22	The trip I took to Northern Spain — I loved th...	>60

Figure 4.9: *Unsatisfying Trip - Group 1. Source: Author's own elaboration based on survey data.*

The second group (see Figure 4.10) comprised respondents aged over 60, who mainly attributed their unsatisfactory experience to not booking tours conducted in their native language.

ID	bad_trip_story	age_group
17	Not booking an organized tour when going somew...	>60
20	Not hiring a tour guide in countries where I d...	>60

Figure 4.10: *Unsatisfying Trip - Group 2. Source: Author's own elaboration based on survey data.*

Satisfying Trip

For the question “Which trip or vacation best represents your way of choosing how to travel? Tell us about the destination: how you chose it, why it reflects you, etc.”, two groups were also identified. The first group (see Figure 4.11) included both young adults (25–35) and older participants (>60). These respondents typically described trips in which they visited multiple destinations, most often in Europe, a continent that enables visiting several cities within a single trip.

ID	representative_trip	age_group
3	It's hard to choose because I've been lucky to...	25-35
7	I like to travel to places which have ancient ...	25-35
13	I recently visited Portugal (Porto & Lisbon) a...	25-35
16	Italy 2024: the itinerary was organized by my ...	>60
17	I like vacations at beach destinations and org...	>60
22	Europe in general — I visited many destination...	>60
24	A trip I took to southern Chile — the Lake Dis...	>60

Figure 4.11: *Satisfying Trip - Group 1. Source: Author's own elaboration based on survey data.*

The second group (see Figure 4.12) comprised two respondents, both young adults, who expressed a preference for visiting multiple destinations, including cruises, while highlighting the importance of relaxation as a core element of their ideal trip.

ID	representative_trip	age_group
11	A multi-destination trip, whether national or ...	25-35
15	I chose a family trip in 2018 to Miami and Orl...	35-59

Figure 4.12: *Satisfying Trip - Group 2. Source: Author's own elaboration based on survey data.*

Organizing a Vacation

In the question “Imagine organising a vacation. Sketch a short story of your choice: what would be the 3–4 main scenes?”, each step was analysed separately using TF–IDF vectorisation. In the first stage, respondents primarily focused on defining the destination, often new or unexplored places, and aligning it with their available budget (see Figure 4.13).

grams	tfidf
choose place	0.052705
don know	0.043365
choose destination	0.043127
plan advance	0.040000
destination like	0.040000
choose greece	0.040000
place don	0.029935
understand budget	0.028284
decide date	0.028284
morocco walk	0.028284

Figure 4.13: *Organizing a Vacation - Step 1. Source: Author's own elaboration based on survey data.*

The second stage (see Figure 4.14) was mainly described by planning logistics, such as defining travel dates, purchasing plane tickets, booking accommodation, and comparing different options.

The third stage focused mainly on defining the itinerary and selecting activities at the destination (see Figure 4.15). The optional fourth stage (see Figure 4.16) often repeated previous elements, such as defining accommodation or activities, confirming their importance in the final stages of trip planning.

Choosing Between Two options

Most participants (72%) preferred option B, primarily due to the possibility of free cancellation. Some also mentioned reviews as a secondary factor. Conversely, those who chose option A (28%) mainly cited price as the decisive factor. Figure 4.17 displays the most frequent bigrams for each group.

grams	tfidf
choose place date	0.040000
compare price website	0.040000
night tent moonlight	0.040000
search flight accommodation	0.040000
find travel agency	0.028284
travel agency satisfy	0.028284
stay apartment day	0.023094
train venice stay	0.023094
weather decide date	0.023094
venice stay apartment	0.023094

Figure 4.14: *Organizing a Vacation - Step 2. Source: Author's own elaboration based on survey data.*

grams	tfidf
cruise greek island	0.053061
ride artxanda funicular	0.040000
choose go stay	0.040000
buy travel insurance	0.040000
greek island istanbul	0.029935
like cruise greek	0.029935
ride camel spend	0.023094
plane train ticket	0.023094
sleep cabin isolated	0.023094
place buy plane	0.023094

Figure 4.15: *Organizing a Vacation - Step 3. Source: Author's own elaboration based on survey data.*

Choosing Method

The embedding similarity analysis for the question “If you had to teach someone your method of choosing, which 3 fundamental steps would you tell them to follow?” yielded a single cluster containing 11 responses (see Figure 4.19). This group comprised mainly young adults (25–35) and a smaller proportion of older respondents (>60). Both embedding similarity and TF–IDF analyses highlighted a consistent decision-making pattern: beyond defining the destination, respondents placed strong emphasis on checking recommendations, verifying accommodation availability, and planning the trip in advance.

Based on these insights, the decision-making process for this group can be summarised in three steps:

1. Define & Learn: Decide on the type of trip and preferred destination, and gather initial information about the location.

	grams	tfidf
	choose activity destination	0.040000
	check eat etc	0.040000
	search apartment hotel	0.040000
	walk experience custom	0.028284
	look book activity	0.028284
	know custom local	0.028284
	consider stay day	0.028284
	get know custom	0.028284
	offer stroll street	0.028284
	excursion offer stroll	0.028284

Figure 4.16: *Organizing a Vacation - Step 4. Source: Author’s own elaboration based on survey data.*

Option A			Option B		
	bigram	tfidf		bigram	tfidf
0	price review	0.285714	0	free cancellation	0.473246
1	number review	0.142857	1	good rating	0.070357
2	base review	0.142857	2	number review	0.069786
3	short particular	0.045175	3	cancellation yes	0.051928
4	trip relatively	0.045175	4	cancellation good	0.040191
5	quantity review	0.045175	5	rating free	0.040191
6	relatively short	0.045175	6	well rating	0.032925
7	round trip	0.045175	7	cancellation help	0.031329
8	particular commitment	0.045175	8	sure free	0.031329
9	level quantity	0.045175	9	help decide	0.031329
10	consider level	0.045175	10	mind cancel	0.024494
11	commitment consider	0.045175	11	reassuring thing	0.024494
12	assume round	0.045175	12	thing change	0.024494

Figure 4.17: *Group A and B. Source: Author’s own elaboration based on survey data.*

2. Check & Compare: Review recommendations, compare accommodation and transport options, and verify availability.
3. Plan & Book: Create a detailed plan, book accommodations and key activities in advance, and prepare financially.

Advice to Their “Past Self”

For the question “If instead you had to give 3 pieces of advice to your past self about organising a vacation, what would you say?”, two groups were identified. The first (see Figure 4.19) included a majority of older participants (>60) but also a considerable number of young adults (25–35).

The main themes extracted were as follows:

- Good preparation:
 - Read offers carefully and understand what is included.
 - Plan and book early, especially for flights and hotels.

ID	age_group	method_full
1	35-59	Establish an area to explore. Look for the che...
2	25-35	Check and compare availability of accommodatio...
5	25-35	Be aware of travel/transport options. If you d...
6	25-35	First, decide what kind of vacation you want. ...
11	25-35	Search for reviews, recommendations, or ask ac...
12	25-35	Choose a destination you like. Choose the righ...
13	25-35	I would highly suggest comparing reviews for h...
15	35-59	Already have in mind the place you want to vis...
20	>60	Decide the places to visit beforehand. Check t...
21	>60	Know where you want to go. Learn as much as po...
25	35-59	Check the weather and avoid rain and cold. Try...

Figure 4.18: *Choosing Method Group*. Source: Author’s own elaboration based on survey data.

ID	age_group	advice_full_clean
2	25-35	read the complete offers be flexible to pay a ...
16	>60	plan well in advance find a good airline with ...
18	25-35	book further in advance ask for advice and rev...
22	>60	organize it yourself listen to advice from tho...
23	>60	get informed by people who know the destinatio...

Figure 4.19: *Advice to “Past Self” - Group 1*. Source: Author’s own elaboration based on survey data.

- Get informed from reliable sources, such as experienced travelers, review sites, and travel forums.
- Choose Carefully:
 - Quality and reliability matter.
 - Choose hotels with at least 3 stars or good reviews.
 - Select transfers carefully.
- Spend Smart:
 - Be willing to pay a bit more for better quality and comfort.
 - Balance between booking in advance and leaving room for spontaneous activities.

The second group (see Figure 4.20) consisted primarily of young adults (25–35), along with a few older respondents (>60). The main pieces of advice identified from this group were:

- Plan with time but leave some room for spontaneous experiences.
- Take your time to compare options.

- Book tours to get to know better the city.
- Check transportation.

ID	age_group	advice_full_clean
5	25-35	always double check transportation details not...
11	25-35	some destinations require more time evaluate t...
12	25-35	don t take too much clothing only what s neces...
17	>60	try to get to know as much as possible about t...
20	>60	don t rent cars in certain places because the ...

Figure 4.20: *Advice to “Past Self” - Group 2.* Source: Author’s own elaboration based on survey data.

Defining the Destination

The question “When you organised your last vacation, did you have a list of destinations in mind? How did you make your final choice?” produced two groups. The first (see Figure 4.21) comprised mainly young adults (25–35) and a few older participants (>60). Most respondents began with a list of potential destinations, narrowing it down based on preferences such as activities, local events, and desired experiences. Some excluded destinations considered overly touristic, while a few made spontaneous choices without a predefined list, balancing planning with flexibility.

destination_list_choice	age_group	clean
Yes, I had several destinations in mind from I...	25-35	yes i had several destinations in mind from it...
When I organized my last vacation, I did start...	25-35	when i organized my last vacation i did start ...
My last planned vacation was actually quite ra...	25-35	my last planned vacation was actually quite ra...
I had a list of destinations, but the route wa...	25-35	i had a list of destinations but the route was...
I didn't have a list of destinations nor did I...	35-59	i didn t have a list of destinations nor did i...
Yes, I had a list of destinations — I only rul...	>60	yes i had a list of destinations i only ruled ...
Yes. I had a list of destinations.	>60	yes i had a list of destinations

Figure 4.21: *Defining the Destination - Group 1.* Source: Author’s own elaboration based on survey data.

The second group (see Figure 4.22) included only young adults. Their responses focused strongly on practical factors such as cost and time availability, indicating decisions guided more by feasibility and affordability than by emotional preference.

Information Saturation

As shown in Figure 4.23, most participants reported stopping their search once they had gathered essential information, such as dates, accommodation, transport, and prices, that made them feel confident in their decision. Avoiding information

destination_list_choice	age_group	clean
i did and the choice was made based on where i...	25-35	i did and the choice was made based on where i...
i did. i made my final choice based on how muc...	25-35	i did i made my final choice based on how much...
i always weigh options and see. And yes, there...	25-35	i always weigh options and see and yes there a...

Figure 4.22: *Defining the Destination - Group 2. Source: Author's own elaboration based on survey data.*

overload was a key trigger to stop searching. For example, one respondent noted that social media can sometimes create unnecessary information overload, promoting distrust rather than clarity. If given more time, some respondents indicated they would have explored nearby destinations, searched for better deals, or extended their stay, while a few felt no need to add anything further.

grams	tfidf
option price reference	0.040000
know exactly destination	0.028284
exactly destination want	0.028284
work tired search	0.023094
place didn city	0.023094
find nice campsite	0.023094
look carefully area	0.023094
find deal work	0.023094
campsite stay add	0.023094
agree place look	0.023094

Figure 4.23: *Top Trigrams for Information Saturation. Source: Author's own elaboration based on survey data.*

4.3.4 Attributes Refinement

Combined with the results presented above, responses to the question “Is there something important we haven’t asked you but that influenced your decision? Tell us about it.” provided additional insights for attribute refinement. Although few participants provided responses, some noteworthy comments included:

- “...the opportunity to learn something new. Whether it’s history, local traditions, or even trying a completely new activity.”
- “Ticket prices and promotions always influence my decision.”
- “I listen to other travelers’ stories and take what might interest me.”

Finally,here put the final attributes to be included in the final survey.

Chapter 5

Discussion

5.1 Qualitative Approach

In the Chapter 2, section 2.1, it was described some potential risks that may appear when developing and conducting a qualitative interview. One of them is compliance bias, where responses could be influenced by participants' personal impression of what they were expected to answer. This was addressed by avoiding any disclosure of the project's purpose and by formulating questions without references to what other people might do. Interviewees were simply invited to participate in an interview, and once the session began, they were explained only that the topic was tourism before moving directly to the questions. The approach followed the principles of the "Mom Test" described by Rob Fitzpatrick, where participants are asked "questions that even your mom could answer honestly" [34]. Another potential risk concerned offset bias, in which participants might be forced to reflect on problems they were not aware of or to consider certain issues as more complex than they normally would. This was mitigated by avoiding the introduction of unfamiliar terms and by ensuring that the evaluation of a problem remained entirely with the interviewee. Finally, speculation bias was the last potential risk mentioned, where participants could be asked to predict their own behaviour in hypothetical future situations. Since people are not generally good at determining what they would do in an hypothetical scenario that never happened to them, participants were instead asked about past and present experiences, and to tell "stories" about what they normally do and don't do. In this way, deeper questions were asked progressively and with patience, as individuals are not able to correctly determine the underlying reasons for their own behavior [34]. It is important to note that this exercise did not involve speculation bias, since participants were not asked to predict hypothetical future behaviours. Instead, they were asked to apply their usual, real-life trip planning process to the case of Ascoli

Piceno, following the same steps, tools, and resources they normally use.

In this way, the approach sought to address the limitations of reliability and subjectivity. On the other hand, although the process was labour-intensive, only ten interviews were conducted, and generalisability was not considered a limitation, since the main purpose of this first stage was to generate a list of attributes to be tested in the following stages, and with the final survey, the larger sample makes generalisation possible.

Chapter 6

Conclusion

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Appendix

A. Example of Qualitative Interview from Previous Project

Interviewee's information: 27 years, Female, MSc student.

Interviewer: What are the main characteristics you consider from a place, when deciding your holidays?

Interviewee: I consider mainly the season of the place I'm going. Also I prefer to go to new places, rather than already known ones. Depending on my budget, I'll look a place abroad or the country in which I'm living.

Interviewer: What makes a city unique/different from another, for you?

Interviewee: For me, the experience/tours that the city offers. Historical monuments that I can visit are also important. Taking into account this, also the transportation available to move around and get to different points of it. I also like the food experiences that I may have, so I'll look for specific dishes of the city I'm going to.

Interviewer: Do you prefer being autonomous when looking for things to do/see or rely on agencies and organize activities by a third party?

Interviewee: Depends, if I'm doing a short trip, I would rely on an agency because I have very short time to go to places, so if it is already organized it would be better. If it is a long trip, I prefer to be into the culture of the place, going around, losing myself in the city, so I prefer to be autonomous. Also, if my trip includes more than one city, I usually search some combo of more than one city tour or experience. For example, in Naples I saw some ship experience that takes you to different Islands, or I know that Firenze and Pisa have some convention that sells some pack that includes both cities.

Interviewer: Do you choose tourists packs (accommodation, meals, transport, activities included) or plan out everything yourself?

Interviewee: I plan where to sleep and nothing else. When I'm in the city, I start searching for packs that it can provide me. I look for packs and guides that offer me some city tour, get to know more from inside the city, recommendations

from a local person.

Interviewer: When choosing a spot, do you research its popularity and then decide whether to go or not?

Interviewee: No, if it is a place I want to go, it doesn't matter if other people go or not.

Interviewer: Give me three characteristics that your vacation spot must have.

Interviewee: History/Traditions, Food, Accessibility/Transport.

B. Example of Qualitative Interview from Actual Thesis

Interviewee's information: Italian, male, 24 years old.

[Interviewer] Can you describe your last vacation? Not so much what you did while you were on vacation, but how you organized it? Starting from home, deciding to go on vacation and the whole planning phase.

[Interviewee] What I usually do is open... I don't know if you know Notion. Yes, it's a note-taking app, let's say, in an organized way. And I create a file for the trip I want to take—in this case, it was Rome. And I write down day by day what I want to do. To do that, I do research online, maybe look for ideas from other itineraries I can find. And then I adjust it based on how much I want to walk, what I want to see, what I'm interested in. But more or less that's the approach, and it also depends on price, how to get there, if I can go by public transport or not, or if I can drive there...

[Interviewer] Describe in detail this Rome trip. So how many days you stayed, what you did the first day, where you found the information... Actually, if you can share your screen, maybe we can see exactly... practically how you searched, also for sleeping arrangements. To see the other options you mentioned, it's really useful. Thank you.

[Interviewee] So, this is the schedule. This is the trip to Rome. It says seven days here, but I think it was actually eight, right? Seven, okay. So for each day there's also the arrival date. In the end I drove, so I didn't have to worry about transportation. As for attractions in Rome, it wasn't very difficult, I mean... it's a very famous city... there are lots of places one can go, so I just tried to make the itineraries a bit organized, so the Pantheon is not too far from Campo...

[Interviewer] So you went by memory for the Rome attractions? You didn't have to search what to see in Rome?

[Interviewee] No, I searched for that too. I looked up "one-week itinerary in Rome". And I compared various ones, but I don't remember exactly which

itinerary I used. But I searched, opened Google, looked up "Rome itinerary", or another thing I did was ask ChatGPT to help me compare them.

[Interviewer] So to give you the actual itinerary and maybe see what was closer, what was farther?

[Interviewee] Yes, even though I must say that when it comes to geographical distance it's not very good?

[Interviewer] Oh no?

[Interviewee] I didn't really find it helpful. Sorry, do you hear the noise? Can you hear it?

[Interviewer] No, we don't hear anything.

[Interviewee] Perfect. Yes, like if you tell it "make me an itinerary considering distance," sometimes it gets it wrong.

[Interviewer] It makes a few blunders.

[Interviewee] Exactly. But if you give it itineraries that already consider distance, the ones written by people who actually took the trip and maybe give you tips, then I find them useful—you can give those a try.

[Interviewer] Okay, so you searched on Google and what did you find?

[Interviewee] Well, usually blogs. I usually go to independent blogs, so travelers—maybe families who like to travel and write—or posts on Reddit.

[Interviewer] Families, but were you traveling with family, with friends, alone?

[Interviewee] A friend who hosted me.

[Interviewer] Okay, so maybe it didn't feel strange to take advice from families? Or maybe you thought: "Well, in the end, the things to see..." Or maybe you were more interested in advice from people your age or travel style?

[Interviewee] Let's say what I wanted to do in Rome was a city visit, the cultural side. See monuments, maybe go to a few museums, so I think that kind of trip is very popular, also with tourists from abroad. Maybe, I don't know, nightlife, stuff like that—obviously I would've looked for other kinds of blogs, I would've looked specifically...

[Interviewer] You said independent blogs—why independent? What do you mean? Not affiliated with... tell me, tell me.

[Interviewee] Usually agencies charge money. It's a bit tricky—maybe you find fairly generic itineraries on agency websites. I had to find it myself. Then, I don't know, I get a bit... how to say... maybe unfairly... when I realize it's an agency, or maybe even if it's a supposedly independent blog, when I feel like maybe they're recommending a place not because they genuinely liked it, but maybe because they're getting paid, or they get commission for sending people there. It's not necessarily a bad thing.

[Interviewer] But it puts you in a different mindset, you're saying?

[Interviewee] I sense a bias from them.

[Interviewer] Sure. Listen, do you ever get inspired by images? Do you search on social media through hashtags or things like that?

[Interviewee] I don't think I've ever used hashtags. I don't even know if people use them. Like I don't go looking for them—maybe it's happened... not so much for Rome, but maybe for mountain hikes or things like that where you get a view... it shows you the scenery. So yeah, it's happened, but I didn't look for it on purpose—it's more something that just popped up, so I got curious and maybe decided to visit it.

[Interviewer] Okay. So you're saying if it pops up in front of me, sure, but it's not a method I use to search—right? Now try to make a little memory effort if you can. Try to imagine when you were younger and maybe went with your parents. Did you ever go somewhere with them? Can you remember how the process worked—maybe your mom or dad took care of it, maybe they went to a travel agency... I don't know, can you remember anything, even vaguely? Obviously not the whole process but anything at all?

[Interviewee] I think so—like yes... but I was really little. They probably relied on agencies. Then there was a period where we did another kind of trip, and it was more based on word-of-mouth. My father also... I mean he had internet access quite early on compared to... like in the early 2000s I think it wasn't that common yet. And even then, back then there were blogs too, though fewer than now. I think he did more or less what I do now, but with fewer tools. But he probably also relied a lot on personal word-of-mouth. Advice from a friend who had the same passions. But yes, surely for a couple of trips they used agencies, though I think only a few.

[Interviewer] Okay, now I'll have you play a role. If you can share your screen again. I'll give you the name of a city. Imagine we're friends and I suggest this city to you... and you show me what process you would follow to decide if it's a place to go or not, if you would go or not. What would you search, what would you look at—photos, text, you tell me. I give you the city name. We're friends and I say "Hey, I think a good place to visit is Ascoli Piceno."

[Interviewee] How many days?

[Interviewer] I don't know. You decide.

[Interviewee] What to see in five days. So... I'd go by car because in winter with transportation... driving is best. So what I would do is check out all these websites I saw. No, this one for example I wouldn't look at... not right now at least.

[Interviewer] Say everything out loud—even what comes to mind. Like "No, ugly," "Nice," "This is boring"—tell me everything that pops into your head. I'm

the voice in your head—go, speak!

[Interviewee] Like TripAdvisor! It's really useful in my opinion, maybe for finding... I don't know... I usually use it more for checking if a restaurant is good, if it's rated well. I'd close it for now in this phase because I wouldn't use it. This site though, which reviews places, tells me opening times, if you need tickets... this is the kind of site I'd look at. Same here, I imagine they're doing about the same thing. And here's ChatGPT giving me more information. And what I would do then... you can't see because I didn't share my screen properly—I only shared the page—but I'd reopen the Notion file from before and start writing notes.

[Interviewer] Okay, but after this quick glance... would you say “Alright, let's go, let's do this trip,” or “No, boring, I'll look for something else”?

[Interviewee] Ah, for Ascoli Piceno in particular?

[Interviewer] Yes, see if I convinced you. I threw it out there—we're friends and now you have to decide.

[Interviewee] Then I also need to check one more important thing.

[Interviewer] Go ahead, tell me.

[Interviewee] How long it takes to get there. Everything counts, so... yeah, it takes a while!

[Interviewer] Have you ever been there? Have you ever looked around that area? Have you ever been in those parts?

[Interviewee] I was in the car a lot as a kid, but I was in a seaside area. So, let's say... the first thing I think is that I feel kind of in the middle of nowhere. A positive thing in terms of, maybe, if you're interested in hiking—though it's not even easy to find someone willing to do it—if I were interested in that type of excursion, I'd say let's go. One element that makes me think ‘maybe I shouldn't go’ is that the town of Ascoli Piceno seems like a fairly small city, and the monuments don't seem unforgettable. So, usually... when do I go to that kind of little village? When there are a lot of them around. So maybe I can go to Ascoli Piceno for a couple of days: visit it the first day, do some hikes nearby on the second day, and then go somewhere else on the third. This type of trip would require a lot of time to organize, also because for sure there are far fewer websites that recommend these kinds of trips.

[Interviewer] What do you mean by “there are fewer websites that recommend these kinds of trips”?

[Interviewee] Not necessarily that there are ones that discourage these kinds of trips—not in the sense of being positive or negative. Rome, Ravenna... these are more popular places, so it's easier to find more websites of that kind.

[Interviewer] And Ascoli instead... a small village, a little town near other little towns—do you imagine it more or less like that?

[Interviewee] I would only go if I managed to organize—another trip comes to mind that I planned, maybe not on Notion... maybe it's somewhere on Drive—in Tuscany, where we did a road trip.

[Interviewer] Kind of on the road, going where it happens.

[Interviewee] Exactly, and of course we visited the main cities, the ones you usually include as tourist destinations—Pisa, Florence... but we also went to Livorno, for example, which I would have never visited intentionally if I hadn't been on a road trip.

[Interviewer] So you passed by, saw Livorno and said, "okay, let's stop," right? Not that...

[Interviewee] We organized it specifically to see as many cities as possible in Tuscany. But if someone had told me, "Let's go to Livorno"... I would have said absolutely not. We went to Livorno because it was part of the bigger Tuscany trip... yes.

[Interviewer] And then you went to Livorno—did you like it?

[Interviewee] No, not really. I don't think it's... I mean, we went, we stayed for a few hours, because we didn't feel like there was much else to see. We went to the seafront.

[Interviewer] Continuing that Tuscany tour, where else did you go besides Florence, Lucca, Pisa? Besides Livorno?

[Interviewee] We went to Rosignano Solvay, for example. The white beach... we wouldn't have gone there on purpose, but since we were nearby, it was interesting.

[Interviewer] For example, Rosignano—the beach of Rosignano. Did you discover it while already there by doing a search, or did you look it up before leaving?

[Interviewee] Before leaving, we had the entire itinerary.

[Interviewer] The whole itinerary planned beforehand. And how did you find Rosignano? Did you search something like "beaches," "unforgettable places," or was it suggested by someone?

[Interviewee] Now I couldn't tell you the first time I heard about it. But it's very interesting because the beach turned white due to industrial waste dumped into the water. So I remembered it, and since our goal was a tour of Tuscany, I said, "Let's pass through there, and have a beach day."

[Interviewer] While organizing this Tuscany tour, did you discover anything on blogs—something you didn't know before, but after seeing the pictures, felt inspired to include?

[Interviewee] Yes, yes. There are various little Tuscan villages, I forget their names now... I'm terrible with names.

[Interviewer] Don't worry about it.

[Interviewee] There are these tiny villages, unreachable by public transport. I probably wouldn't have gone from Bergamo to that place. But they were beautiful places. Even within the overall Tuscany trip, they were a great added value—also inland.

[Interviewer] And you chose them based on images, or reviews you read?

[Interviewee] Both... beautiful images—the Tuscan inland is very scenic, anywhere you go you find beautiful things—and also based on reviews from people who recommended them. So even there, we...

[Interviewer] Listen, I have to ask—since you were in Tuscany, you definitely ate well. I have no doubt! How did you find where to eat? Or did you just stop wherever? Like, “I want to eat Florentine steak.”

[Interviewee] Yes, for example, the Florentine steak... since I have friends who've traveled and some who live in Tuscany, I got some advice from them. Then sometimes we just stopped wherever. In those villages, there are very few places anyway—we just sat down and that was it. Other times we searched...

[Interviewer] Have you ever gone to a place specifically just to eat something?

[Interviewee] Yes, for example, there was this restaurant someone recommended to eat Florentine steak at a decent price. And we went there on purpose.

[Interviewer] Since you're talking about price—going back to Ascoli, from the two images you saw earlier... would you expect it to be more expensive, cheaper, or the same as, say, Ravenna?

[Interviewee] That's a good question... well... since I'd be going by car...

[Interviewer] Show me an example of how you'd estimate costs—also for accommodation. I don't know, would you look on Airbnb, Booking... Show me how you'd roughly estimate the costs.

[Interviewee] Usually the first thing I do is go on Airbnb and Booking. I prefer Airbnb for these types of trips, because usually I travel with a group and we like to have one meal out and one at home. The nice thing about going by car is that you don't need to book in the city center...

[Interviewer] Open Airbnb and show me—you'd look at the Airbnb map, right? Because that gives you a better idea of prices in the area since, as you said, you can drive around.

[Interviewee] Exactly. A bit outside, for example here I see 42 euros per night. And yeah, what I'd do is say, “okay, that's the price.” It's true a lot is already booked.

[Interviewer] The fact that it's mostly booked—does that give you a positive or negative impression of the place?

[Interviewee] About the quality of the place—it tells me nothing. But in itself, it gives me a negative feeling because I think, if I see that many places are already

booked, the risk is that what's left might be quite expensive. So it might be hard to find good prices.

[Interviewer] So, looking at these prices—you put the end of August, right? With these prices, would you think, “No way, it's too much”? You put three people... no—five people for four nights.

[Interviewee] No, I'd have to check what that place looks like. 35 euros per night, this one, which is the cheapest per person.

[Interviewer] Stefano, I was just saying thanks because you're dedicating so much time to this—really, thank you. Very kind. So you were saying this is more or less the price. And for food, you said you'll decide once there, right? I think you said you do Airbnb also to optimize the fact that sometimes you eat in, sometimes out?

[Interviewee] Yes, though... I mean... it's not even guaranteed. It depends a lot. For example, I might consider staying near a place and only need a few hours to visit it all. So maybe I just pass through...

[Interviewer] You wouldn't even stay the night, you mean?

[Interviewee] No, I'd go somewhere else—toward the next city.

[Interviewer] Sure, absolutely, okay. So, imagine a nearby city—would you go on Maps... what would you do to see what else to pair with it?

[Interviewee] I'd look it up on Google. For example, for these types of trips... just for no particular reason... maybe “what to see in the Marche,” or in Abruzzo too—maybe we could combine those two regions and decide based on that...

[Interviewer] ...based on a mix of things. So not a single city. Maybe a city fits in because you associate two or three nearby things and say, “Hey, since we're here and it takes just a few hours to see it, let's go.” Right? More or less?

[Interviewee] Exactly. I wouldn't plan a trip just for a city like that.

[Interviewer] Let me ask you a couple of direct questions about the city. Have you ever heard of olive all'ascolana? You know what they are? Have you eaten them?

[Interviewee] I've eaten them, even from the place itself.

[Interviewer] So you know they're from Ascoli? That they're called Ascolane because of the city? Okay. Oh, you ate them from the place—maybe when you were a kid on holiday?

[Interviewee] No, someone brought them to me.

[Interviewer] Ah, someone brought them—like a friend from there? Someone from the city?

[Interviewee] A friend from the Marche region.

[Interviewer] Have you ever heard of the Quintana?

[Interviewer] Okay. Can you quickly look it up on Google and tell me what

comes up and what you think it is? Like if it sparks any thoughts.

[Interviewee] I don't know... it makes me think of something like the Palio di Siena, in the sense of: a tradition handed down from the past, something that's stayed around. Then the horses—it seems like a game...

[Interviewer] Is it something that might interest you to see? Or do you absolutely not care?

[Interviewee] Yes, I'd be interested. I think... in that famous Tuscany trip, we also included the Palio di Siena... We even planned it that way—we timed our Siena visit for when the Palio was happening.

[Interviewer] And how did you find out it was during the Palio? I doubt you knew the dates by heart—I don't even know them.

[Interviewee] No, let's say that when...

[Interviewer] So when planning the Siena part, you remembered the Palio and thought "Let's see when it is." You already knew about the Palio, it wasn't something you had to look up? You just knew it.

[Interviewee] Yes, I knew it.

[Interviewer] Alright. Stefano, thank you. You've been really, really kind. Thank you so much for also sharing your screen and showing everything. I really appreciate the chat. Thank you so much.

[Interviewee] No problem. Thank you guys.

[Interviewer] Thanks a lot. Bye everyone. Franco, I'll text you on WhatsApp.

C. Qualitative Interview Notes

Interview 1 (Male, Italian, 24 years)

- Some important points, and insights:
 - "...look for ideas from other itineraries...". **ONLINE RECOMMENDATION**
 - "...it also depends on price, how to get there, if I can go by public transport or not, or if I can drive there...". **COST TO REACH, ACCESIBILITY BY PUBLIC TRANSPORT**
 - "As for attractions in Rome, it wasn't very difficult, I mean... it's a very famous city... there are lots of places one can go...". **HISTORICAL ATTRACTIONS**
 - "...opened Google, looked up "Rome itinerary", or another thing I did was ask ChatGPT to help me compare them". **AI RECOMMENDATION**
 - "I usually go to independent blogs...". **ONLINE RECOMMENDATION**
 - "...city visit, the cultural side. See monuments, maybe go to a few museums...". **CULTURE , MUSEUMS, HISTORIC MONUMENTS.**
 - "...I feel like maybe they're recommending a place not because they genuinely liked it, but maybe because they're getting paid...". **GENUINE ONLINE RECOMMENDATIONS.**
 - "...it was more based on word-of-mouth.". **PERSONAL RECOMMENDATION**
 - "Like TripAdvisor! It's really useful in my opinion..." . **ONLINE RECOMMENDATION**
 - "This site though, which reviews places, tells me opening times, if you need tickets... this is the kind of site I'd look at.". **INFORMATIVE PAGES**
 - "How long it takes to get there.". **DISTANCE TO REACH, TIME TO REACH**
 - "A positive thing in terms of, maybe, if you're interested in hiking ...". **HIKING, NATURAL LANDSCAPE**
 - "...Ascoli Piceno seems like a fairly small city, and the monuments don't seem unforgettable.". **CITY SIZE, HISTORICAL MONUMENTS**
 - "When there are a lot of them around.". **NEAR TO OTHER TOURISTIC DESTINATIONS**
 - "Rome, Ravenna... these are more popular places, so it's easier to find more websites of that kind.". **INFORMATION AVAILABILITY**
 - "...but we also went to Livorno, for example, which I would have never visited intentionally if I hadn't been on a road trip.". **ROAD TRIP**
 - "We went to the seafront.". **NATURAL LANDSCAPE**
 - "...and also based on reviews from people who recommended them.". **ONLINE RECOMMENDATION**
 - "...someone recommended to eat Florentine steak at a decent price.". **FOOD'S PRICE, LOCAL CUISINE**
 - "...I prefer Airbnb for these types of trips, because usually I travel with a group, and we like to have one meal out and one at home.". **ACCOMMODATION TYPE, AVAILABLE RESTAURANTS**
 - "The nice thing about going by car is that you don't need to book in the city center.". **CITY'S ACCESIBILITY**

- “...in that famous Tuscany trip, we also included the Palio di Siena...”.

LOCAL EVENTS

Interview 2 (Male, Argentinian, 25 years)

- Some important points, and insights:
 - “...right now going to the Argentine coast, with how expensive it is...”.
- **PRICE**
- “...how hard it is to get around, especially during New Year’s—it’s much harder to find good lodging at a fair price.”. **ACCESSIBILITY, PRICE**
- “On one hand, TikTok—honestly, there’s a ton of tourist information there, not so much about prices or packages, but more from people sharing their experiences. And on the other hand, I also use recommendations from friends...”.
- **SOCIAL MEDIA RECOMMENDATION, PERSONAL RECOMMENDATION**
- “...we looked a lot into what the transportation is like there, food prices, which beaches are recommended.”. **PUBLIC TRANSPORT, FOOD PRICE, BEACHES**
- “What interests me most about Italy is the history, and of course everything that comes with it—architecture, culture...”.
- **HISTORIC PLACES, ARCHITECTURE, CULTURE**
- “...I always look for places that have either beaches or nature.” **NATURAL LANDSCAPE**
- “If I don’t know anyone, I usually go to TripAdvisor.”. **PERSONAL RECOMMENDATION, ONLINE RECOMMENDATION**
- “I feel like there are lots of content creators who, in one minute, give you a good summary of the destination’s essence...”.
- **ONLINE RECOMMENDATION, CONCISE RECOMMENDATION**
- “And sometimes Airbnb...I feel like it gives you more of a sense of “hey, I’m actually living here,”...”.
- **LOCAL EXPERIENCE, ACCOMMODATION’S SERVICES**
- “...when it comes to accommodation, what I really look at is three things: location, price, and then what the place offers.”. **ACCOMMODATION LOCATION, PRICE, LOCAL EXPERIENCE**
- “...when planning a trip to Italy, one wants to visit as many cities as possible.”. **NEAR TO OTHER TOURISTIC DESTINATIONS**
- “...I like that it has the Tronto River running right through it.”. **NATURAL LANDSCAPE**
- “...food tourism spots with more traditional dishes...”.
- **LOCAL CUISINE**
- “...opening Google, searching for restaurants, reading reviews, ratings, opinions, checking menu photos.”. **GOOGLE REVIEWS**
- “The fact that it’s close to Florence, which is a place I really want to visit.”.
- **NEAR TO POPULAR CITIES**

Interview 3 (Male, Argentinian, 31 years)

- Some important points, and insights:

- “The way a trip starts is by thinking about the cost to get to that place, or how much it costs.”. **COST TO REACH**
- “...I look more at the distance...”. **DISTANCE TO REACH**
- “Hotels, I usually go to Booking.com, because I’m more into hotels. I prefer hotels over Airbnb because of the built-in conveniences.”.
ACCOMMODATION TYPE, ACCOMMODATION’S SERVICES
- “I’m all in on ChatGPT for itineraries.”. **AI RECOMMENDATION**
- “So I’d look up... literal ways to get to Ascoli.”. **POSSIBILITIES TO REACH**
- “I’d also ask people I know or places like that.”. **PERSONAL RECOMMENDATION**
- “Something I don’t do, but my wife does, is travel agencies.”. **TRAVEL AGENCIES**
- “Also just to get a price range based on the service quality too...”.
ACCOMMODATION PRICE, ACCOMMODATION QUALITY
- “Based on a mix of days where I’d prioritize... I don’t know... Museums and culture, and others where I’d prioritize nature and gastronomy.”.
MUSEUMS, CULTURE, NATURAL LANDSCAPE, CUISINE
- “But it seems like a typical place where you’d want to set up a base and then do some kind of excursions to nearby spots.”. **NEAR TO OTHER TOURISTIC DESTINATIONS**
- “Look, for example, 27 minutes from Ascoli Piceno to the coast. I want to believe the coast must be beautiful just because it’s Italy. So here, it’s very likely I’d want to do this kind of excursion.” **BEACHES**
- “It was such a tiny place that it wasn’t prepared for people to go by car...”.
CAR FIRENDLY
- “First and foremost is Google Maps. Restaurants. I look by distance from where I’m standing, and the stars and reviews.”. **ONLINE RECOMMENDATION, RESTAURANTS’ PROXIMITY**
- “...they usually have a central theme, like: “This is... people come here for this.” If this falls into that category, I’d probably go...” **LOCAL EVENTS**
- “Since its traditional food, I’d try it 100%...” **LOCAL CUISINE**
- “The first thing I’d do is check photos, because I’m way more excited about a mix of city and coast—or water or scenic natural stuff—than just city.”. **NATURAL LANDSCAPE**

Interview 4 (Male, Spain, 25 years)

- Some important points, and insights:
 - “...visit all the beaches in Menorca, which are very beautiful.”. **BEACHES**
 - “Because it was cheaper that way.”. **COST TO REACH**
 - “...the distance we had from the house we rented to the place to visit...”.
CITY’S ACCESSIBILITY
 - “...when it comes to looking on Airbnb, then I’d use 2 or 3 different websites...” **ACCOMMODATION TYPE**
 - “So we can go to the supermarket without any problem, which is important.”. **SUPERMARKETS AVAILABILITY**

- “I’d look for a place near a city. That’s reasonably priced.”.
ACCOMMODATION PRICE
- “...with good reviews—of course, reviews are essential. You always have to check them.”. **ONLINE RECOMMENDATION**
- “...I’d ask if there are museums to visit. Also about restaurants there.”.
MUSEUMS, RESTAURANTS
- “...I’d look for places around it that are also interesting—like natural parks, hiking routes...”. **NEAR TO OTHER TOURISTIC DESTINATIONS, NATURAL LANDSCAPE, HIKING**
- “...visiting nearby mountain areas or coastal areas.”. **NATURAL LANDSCAPE, MOUNTAINS, BEACHES**
- “...but it’s also very important to know the price. Of everything it says you can do.”. **LOCAL PRICES**

Interview 5 (Male, Argentina, 26 years)

- Some important points, and insights:
 - “...the decision to travel to Brazil has to do first with financial reasons.”.
LOCAL PRICE
 - “...we believe it’s a trip that includes several destinations...”. **NEAR TO OTHER TOURISTIC DESTINATIONS**
 - “So everything in terms of entertainment, food, and drink is covered—and accommodation, of course—is covered with everything the cruise includes.”. **PRICE, ACCOMMODATION SERVICE**
 - “...they had prices—or rather packages—that were quite affordable for what they offered...”. **TOURISTIC PACKAGE**
 - “...and also to attend San Fermín—the San Fermín festival.”. **LOCAL EVENTS**
 - “...to organize the trip in such a way that we had a practical triangle in terms of logistics—that is, in terms of travel.”. **ACCESIBILITY**
 - “That route is much cheaper.”. **COST TO REACH**
 - “there’s a lot of traffic and so on. I mean people-traffic.”.
OVERCROWDED
 - “Well, Google has this attractions option...”. **ATTRACTION AVAILABILITY**
 - “This bridge here seems very nice. I think there's a fort or something similar around here. And it seems like a kind of medieval city, but at the same time very well preserved...”. **HISTORIC BUILDINGS**
 - “It’s closer to Rome, which is a major city.”. **NEAR TO POPULAR CITIES**
 - “...I’m obviously going to prioritize pasta or some traditional local food.”.
LOCAL CUISINE
 - “...I generally look for something near the center. Especially when the city’s attractions or most important sites are close to the center.”. **CITY’S ACCESIBILITY**

Interview 6 (Male, Iran, 25 years)

- Some important points, and insights:

- "...the ticket for going back is... Straightly, it was too expensive. And I decided to maybe... find a way to be cheaper. Like, going somewhere else, and then have a flight back to Milan.". **COST TO REACH, PROXIMITY TO OTHER DESTINATIONS**
- "...it was more a historic place, a more historic city.". **HISTORIC BUILDING, HISTORICAL DESTINATION**
- "...the cheap trip we could have there. Like, even, uh, the food. Or, uh, the price of the Airbnb, the place of living.". **FOOD PRICE, ACCOMMODATION PRICE**
- "And for historic places, I mean... maybe ChatGPT.". **ONLINE RECOMMENDATION**
- "...best place for us, uh, the castle. They had on the top of the hill... Also, the whole, like, it was, like, an old town there, right? All over the hill.". **HISTORICAL BUILDING**
- "And then...It'll be the location... to see if... I mean, which one is nearer to me.". **DISTANCE TO REACH**
- "Like, an Airbnb or Booking.com, or any other websites regarding this.". **ACCOMMODATION TYPE**
- "...and of course, it's so close to Florence. Because, for example. I can be, like, one day in Pistoia, and then I go to Pisa or Florence to have more fun there.". **NEAR TO POPULAR CITIES, NEAR TO OTHER DESTINATIONS**
- "...it has a better... uh, like, route by bus, or... uh, train, I don't know, uh... any vehicle that, uh, we... I can use to get there.". **AVAILABILITY OF TRANSPORT TO DESTINATION**

Interview 7 (Female, Spain, 21 years)

- Some important points, and insights:
 - "There we looked for hostels...". **ACCOMMODATION TYPE**
 - "Like, finding the cheapest way to make it all work.". **COST TO REACH**
 - "Then for hotels, we looked on both Booking and Trivago...". **ACCOMMODATION TYPE**
 - "We also checked they weren't super far from Vienna, that we could get there by bus or walking in 15 or 20 minutes.". **CITY'S ACCESSIBILITY**
 - "And they're much cheaper than hotels or any hostel. Cleaner and quieter. Breakfast included—also important.". **ACCOMMODATION PRICE, ACCOMMODATION SERVICES**
 - "...we used ChatGPT, we asked it to make us a list of everything.". **ONLINE RECOMMENDATION**
 - "So we do something near the convent.". **ACCESSIBILITY TO TOURISTIC POINTS**
 - "You'd get these huge lines...And I'm like, not worth saving 3 euros.". **OVERCROWDED**
 - "Okay, for that we'd use a mix of Google Maps and TripAdvisor. We'd look at price ranges...". **ONLINE RECOMMENDATION, FOOD PRICES**
 - "Then we look at typical local places...". **LOCAL RESTAURANTS**

- "...we'd decide based on what was best depending on where we were, depending on the monuments and everything we had to see."
- RESTAURANTS' PROXIMITY**
- "So yeah, for me, I always go for the traditional. I really value culinary culture." **LOCAL CUISINE**
- "So for a weekend, it's not worth it to go that far." **DISTANCE TO REACH**
- "Which has more historical stuff...". **HISTORICAL DESTINATION**
- "But you also have to get to the airport 2h early, and then there's the trip afterward to get wherever." **AVAILABILITY OF TRANSPORT TO DESTINATION, DISTANCE TO REACH**
- "Like, if someone told me, "Hey, there's this event in this place," and the tickets are affordable—like, I don't know, 30 or 40€, then yeah, I'd go." **LOCAL EVENT, EVENT PRICE**
- "It's a city that—I mean, architecturally, it's beautiful. The churches inside were gorgeous." **HISTORIC BUILDING**
- "...people are friendly. But in Italy... that's not really a barrier." **LOCAL FRIENDLINESS**

Interview 8 (Male, Colombia, 41 years)

- Some important points, and insights:
 - "I always travel for an electronic music festival." **MUSIC EVENTS**
 - "...hopefully, that city will also have something in terms of modern art." **CULTURE**
 - "...and I try to explore nearby areas as well." **NEAR TO OTHER DESTINATIONS**
 - "...I'd look at how much I'd spend on the festival." **MUSIC EVENT COST**
 - "I go to Booking or Airbnb." **ACCOMMODATION TYPE**
 - "...I look at prices. Based on what I like, the quality." **ACCOMMODATION PRICE, ACCOMMODATION QUALITY**
 - "Then online, I also looked up rankings...". **ONLINE RECOMMENDATION**
 - "...everything is always full all the time." **OVERCROWDED**
 - "...was super expensive—it didn't matter, I was working, so no problem. Now it's a bit different." **FOOD'S PRICE**
 - "...some popular local food places. I also love to visit those." **LOCAL CUISINE**
 - "...I'll open Google and check the top-rated places nearby—what Google Maps recommends." **ONLINE RECOMMENDATION**
 - "The museums... this right here. That's enough to win me over." **MUSEUMS**
 - "Then I'd look up the train." **ACCESIBILITY BY PUBLIC TRANSPORT**
 - "That's awesome. Cool. I'd go... No, I really like it because it has to do with culture." **LOCAL EVENTS, CULTURE**

Interview 9 (Female, Argentina, 30 years)

- Some important points, and insights:

- “We wanted to visit a lot of places in a short time, so we went for capitals or more touristy, well-known places.”. **NEAR TO OTHER DESTINATIONS, PROXIMITY TO POPULAR CITIES, POPULAR CITY**
- “So, we picked locations based on proximity and timing.”. **NEAR TO OTHER DESTINATIONS, DISTANCE TO RECH**
- “We searched a lot of websites from people who had already traveled and had tips or recommendations.”. **ONLINE RECOMMENDATION**
- “So I click on them as a first guide, but then I try to find people I think have more genuine content—not people who were paid to promote.”. **GENUINE ONLINE RECOMMENDATION**
- “I’d go directly to Booking or sites that are focused specifically on accommodation, and another site just for transport.”. **ACCOMMODATION TYPE, AVAILABILITY OF TRANSPORT TO DESTINATION**
- “The first thing I would do is check how long it would take to get there and back from where I’m staying.”. **DISTANCE TO REACH**
- “...I’d try to make the trip out as early as possible to have the whole day to explore. And the return trip as late as possible to also get the most out of that day.”. **VARIETY OF HOURS FOR TRANSPORTATION**
- “...first, look at the location... So first, I check that the area is recommended because it’s close to tourist spots.”. **ACCOMMODATION LOCATION, ACCESSIBILITY TO TOURISTIC POINTS**
- “And also because if I’m going by bus or public transport and won’t have a car, it should be easy to get around...” **CITY’S ACCESSIBILITY**
- “Then I’d set a price range for lodging.”. **ACCOMMODATION PRICE**
- “If there’s a well-known museum, I’d try to dedicate part of the trip to visiting it, but mainly I’d focus on the historical spots.”. **MUSEUMS, HISTORICAL PLACES**
- “If they have any kind of city tour... I’d check if they have local tour guides that give you a general overview of the city.”. **AVAILABILITY OF CITY TOURS**
- “But I try to research the city a bit before going so when I arrive, I know what I’m seeing, what I’m visiting.”. **INFORMATION AVAILABILITY**
- “Maybe it’s known more for food, so I’d look into where to try the local cuisine.”. **LOCAL CUISINE**

Interview 10 (Male, Argentina, 30 years)

- Some important points, and insights:
 - “...before organizing everything was to see what was cheapest in terms of flying in and out.”. **COST TO REACH**
 - “We booked entry and exit through different countries so we could plan a route going from one place to another.”. **NEAR TO OTHER DESTINATIONS**
 - “I had found some different blogs.”. **ONLINE RECOMMENDATIONS**
 - “We mainly stayed in hostels...” **ACCOMMODATION TYPE**

- “We used Omio to compare if it was better to travel by bus, plane, or train between cities. If we could travel overnight to save on lodging, we did that too.”. **AVAILABILITY OF TRANSPORT TO DESTINATION, VARIETY OF HOURS FOR TRANSPORTATION**
- “What we did a lot of was checking which historical places, castles, museums, and such we could book in advance...”. **HISTORICAL PLACES, HISTORICAL BUILDING, MUSEUMS**
- “Then we’d plan the day around that activity we’d already scheduled.”. **ACCESSIBILITY TO TOURISTIC POINTS**
- “...they’re very cultural cities, very rich in culture, especially.”. **CULTURE**
- “Not so many fast-food chains, more traditional food.”. **LOCAL CUISINE**
- “Also, culturally, being out on the street—the people are more laid-back, if you will.”. **LOCAL FRIENDLINESS**
- “So we’d try to eat something simple and cheap at lunchtime.”. **FOOD’S PRICES**
- “A lot from TikTok, social media, blogs.”. **ONLINE RECOMMENDATIONS**
- “...how much it costs to get to each one—on Omio or something like that.”. **COST TO REACH**
- “I’d start looking at it all on Google Maps to see if there are actually things to do and how far away everything is, because if it’s 20 kilometers from the city...”. **ACCESSIBILITY TO TOURISTIC POINTS**
- “I’d search by area—somewhere central, or where I’ll be arriving (train or bus).”. **ACCOMMODATION LOCATION**
- “If it looks good or has the services I need, like towels, a bed, that’s enough.”. **ACCOMMODATION SERVICES**
- “They’re smaller cities, you know, it’s not like Rome or that I’m missing out on Venice.”. **POPULAR CITY**

D. Booking.com Top Words

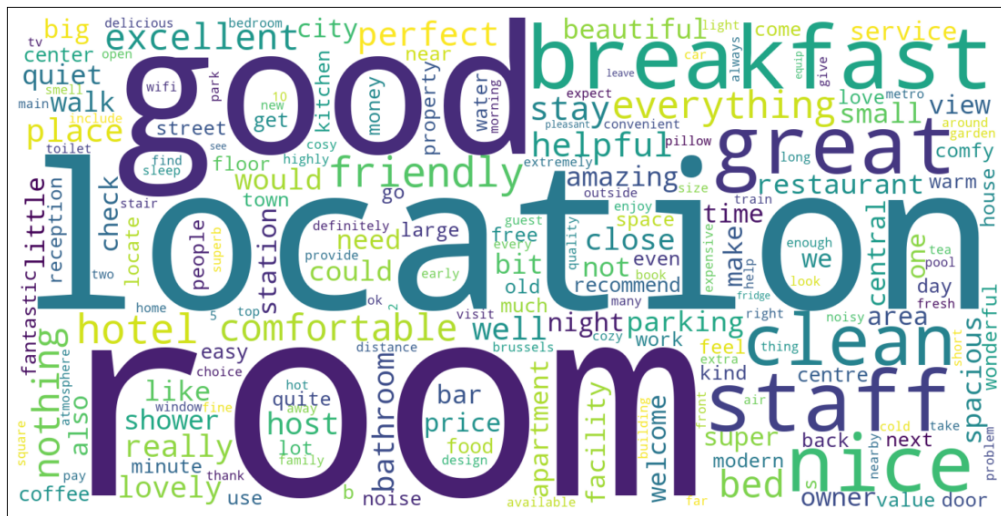


Figure 6.1: *Booking.com Positive Reviews' Top Words.* Source: Author's own elaboration based on a Kaggle's dataset



Figure 6.2: *Booking.com Negative Reviews' Top Words.* Source: Author's own elaboration based on a Kaggle's dataset

E. Explanatory Survey

WELCOME!

This survey is meant to study the wishes of tourists and make them as happy as possible during their trip. Every piece of information you share will be valuable to us. Please answer as thoroughly as you can to help us. There are no right or wrong answers. We are not interested in the “best destinations,” but in your actual choices, even if they are impulsive or not well planned. The answers are anonymous and will be used only for research purposes. There are 10 simple questions (hopefully also fun ones), but it is important that you have at least ten minutes to answer them—so if you don’t have time now, please come back when you can dedicate a moment to us!

PAST TRIPS

1. Tell us about a trip of yours that you were not satisfied with. What would you not do again, especially in the planning phase? **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**
2. Which trip or vacation best represents your way of choosing how to travel? Tell us about the destination: how you chose it, why it reflects you, etc. **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**

ORGANIZING A VACATION

3. Imagine organizing a vacation. Sketch a short story of your choice: what would be the 3–4 main scenes?
 - a. Scene 1 **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**
 - b. Scene 2 **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**
 - c. Scene 3 **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**
 - d. Scene 4 (Optional) **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**

MULTIPLE CHOICE

4. Which of these stories represents you the most?
 - a. I see an offer, check very little, and book the same day.
 - b. I compare 3–4 destinations, read reviews, and book after a few days.
 - c. I check flexibility/free cancellation and decide when I find the right one.
 - d. Others.

ALTERNATIVE CHOICES

Look at the two alternatives and answer the following questions.

Screen A Price: €420 (total) Reviews: 4.2/5 (based on 600 reviews) Free cancellation: NO Pantalla A Precio: 420 € (total) Reseñas: 4,2/5 (basado en 600 reseñas) Cancelación gratuita: NO	Screen B Price: €470 (total) Reviews: 4.6/5 (based on 320 reviews) Free cancellation: YES Pantalla B Precio: 470 € (total) Reseñas: 4,6/5 (basado en 320 reseñas) Cancelación gratuita: Sí
--	---

5. If you had to choose right now, which of the two screens would you pick?
 - a. A.
 - b. B.
6. Which was the decisive piece of information you looked at last before choosing?
(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)

SUGGESTIONS

7. If you had to teach someone your method of choosing, which 3 fundamental steps would you tell them to follow?
 - a. Step 1 **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**
 - b. Step 2 **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**
 - c. Step 3 **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**
8. If instead you had to give 3 pieces of advice to your past self about organizing a vacation, what would you say?
 - a. Step 1 **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**
 - b. Step 2 **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**
 - c. Step 3 **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**

OPEN QUESTIONS

9. When you organized your last vacation, did you have a list of destinations in mind? How did you make your final choice? And among them, was there a destination you said, “No, this is not for me”? Tell us why. **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**
10. When did you feel you had “enough” information to decide? What made you stop searching? And if you had had more time, what would you have added to your research? **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**
11. Is there something important we haven’t asked you but that influenced your decision? Tell us about it. **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**

ASCOLI PICENO (ADD PICTURE)

Ascoli Piceno is a historic city in central Italy, located about 2 hours from Rome and close to the Adriatic coast. It is famous for its medieval towers, Renaissance squares

(such as Piazza del Popolo), local gastronomy (olive all'ascolana), and its well-preserved historic center surrounded by mountains and natural parks.

Reference map: Look at this map and continue to the next section. (ADD MAP)

PRICING

12. Imagine a weekend package in Ascoli Piceno: it includes 2 nights in centrally located accommodation, 1 dinner at a restaurant, and 1 activity of your choice (for example: a museum, guided tour, etc.). Exclude transportation.
- At what price would you consider the product to be priced so low that you would feel the quality couldn't be very good? In euros (€). **(Space to put only numbers)**
 - At what price would you consider the product to be a bargain - a great buy for the money? In euros (€). **(Space to put only numbers)**
 - At what price would you consider the product starting to get expensive, so that it is not out of the question, but you would have to give some thought to buying it? In euros (€). **(Space to put only numbers)**
 - At what price would you consider the product to be so expensive that you would not consider buying it? In euros (€). **(Space to put only numbers)**

TYPE OF TRAVELER

13. When you travel, who takes care of organizing the trip?
- Myself.
 - I organize it with others.
 - Someone else.
14. What is your primary purpose for traveling? You can select up to 2 options.
- See new cities or explore new destinations.
 - Relaxation.
 - Outdoor activities.
 - Cultural attractions.
 - Events: festivals, sports, etc.
15. What type of trip do you usually choose: a short trip, a medium-length trip, or a long one? Please explain the reason for your choice. **(OPEN-ENDED QUESTION)**
16. What type of traveler are you? You can select more than one. You can select up to 2 options.
- Solo traveler.
 - Family traveler.
 - Group traveler.
 - Couple traveler.
17. What is the first place you go to for travel information?
- Google or similar.
 - ChatGPT or similar AIs.
 - Online Platforms as Booking.com.
 - Airbnb, TripAdvisor or similar.
 - Social media.
 - Official destination websites.
 - Travel Blogs.

- h. Travel agencies.
 - i. Personal recommendations.
18. What is your age group?
- a. <25.
 - b. 25-35.
 - c. 35-59.
 - d. >60.
19. Which is your gender?
- a. Male.
 - b. Female.
 - c. Other/I prefer not to say it.
20. Where do you live?
- a. Italy.
 - b. Europe, excluding Italy.
 - c. Asia.
 - d. Africa.
 - e. Oceania.
 - f. North America.
 - g. Central America.
 - h. South America.
21. What is your current occupation?
- a. Employed.
 - b. Self-employed.
 - c. Student.
 - d. Retired.
 - e. Unemployed.
 - f. Other.

F. Explanatory Survey Results

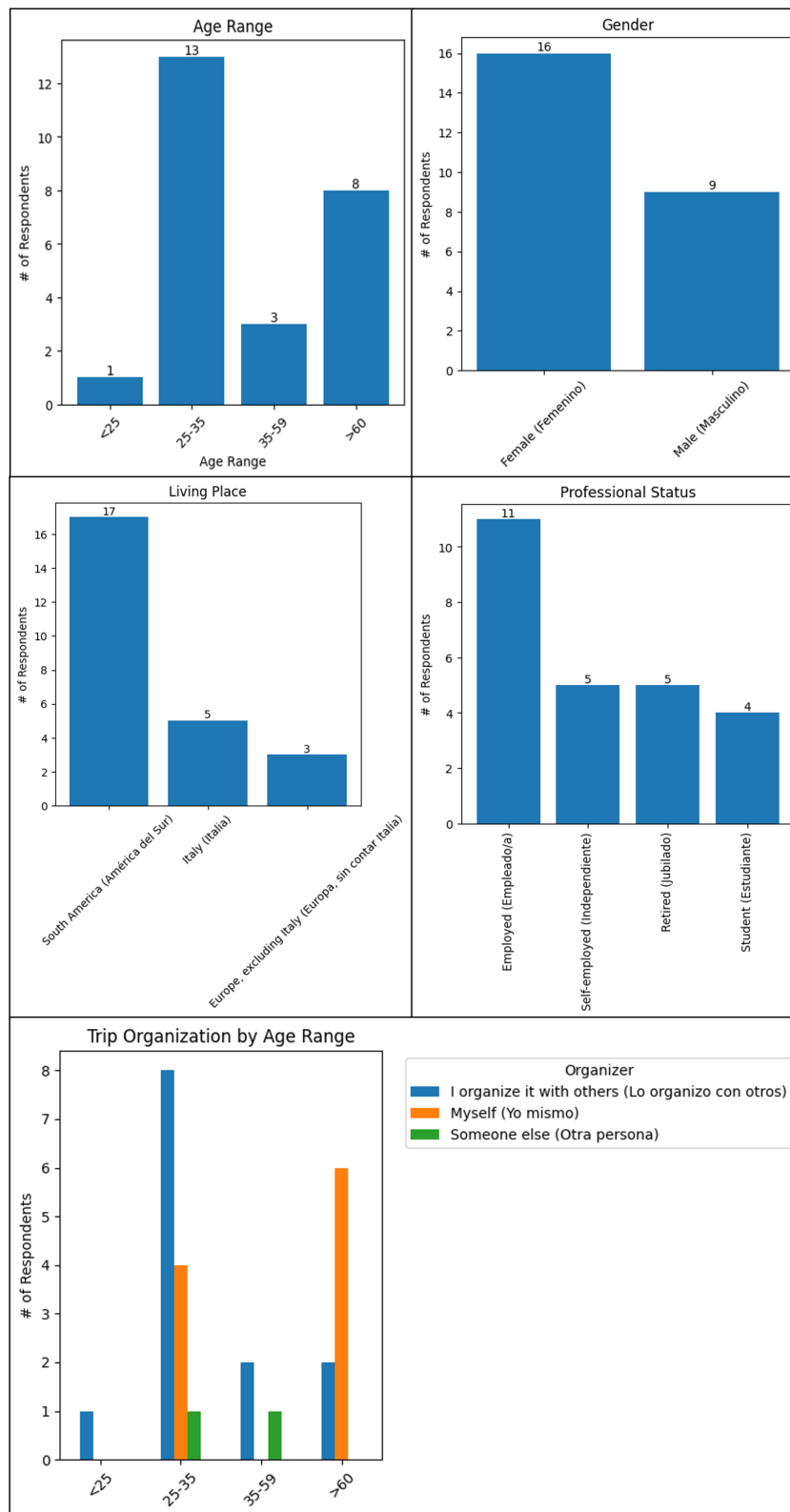


Figure 6.3: Description of Explanatory Survey's Respondents. Source: Author's own elaboration based on survey data.

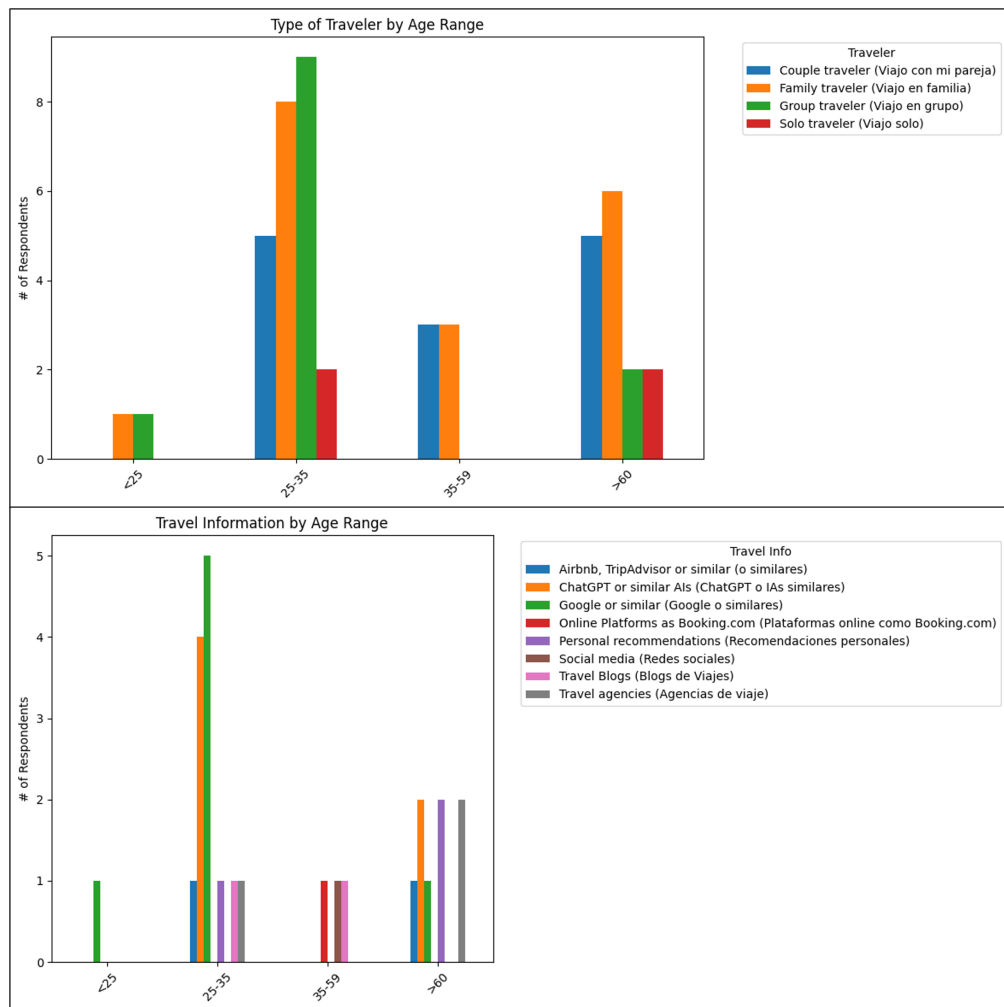
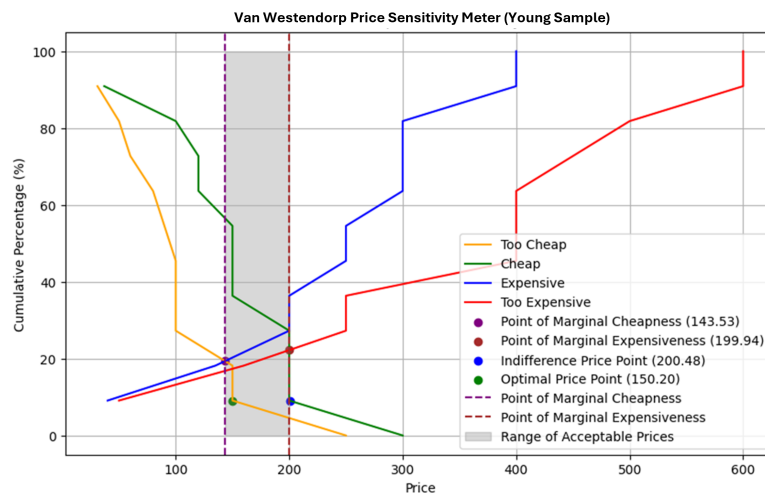
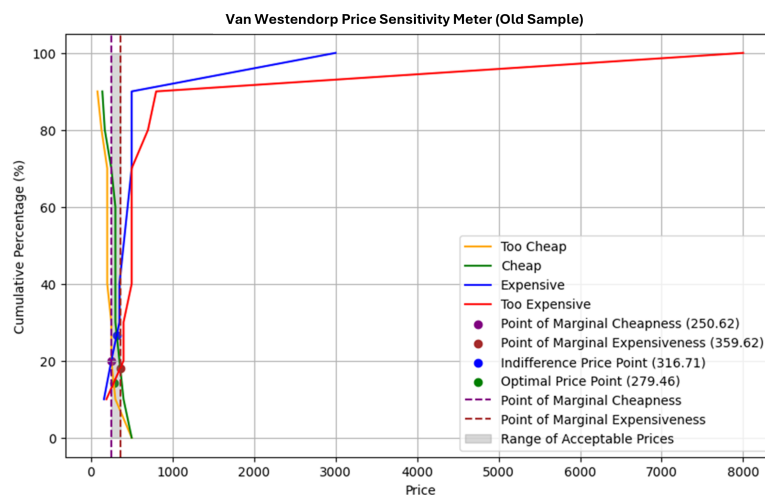


Figure 6.4: *Description of Explanatory Survey's Respondents. Source: Author's own elaboration based on survey data.*

G. Van Westendorp Results by Age Group



Van Westendorp Analysis:
 Point of Marginal Cheapness: 143.53
 Point of Marginal Expensiveness: 199.94
 Indifference Price Point: 200.48
 Optimal Price Point: 150.20



Van Westendorp Analysis:
 Point of Marginal Cheapness: 250.62
 Point of Marginal Expensiveness: 359.62
 Indifference Price Point: 316.71
 Optimal Price Point: 279.46

Figure 6.5: *Van Westendorp Pricing Method by Age Group. Source: Author's own elaboration based on survey data.*